

Psych Hons Preliminary Abstracts 2025

ID: 1 | **Method:** Quantitative

Children's Judgements of Multimodal Emotional Cues

Children are constantly engaged in the process of interpreting various multimodal visual and auditory cues from people around them to form social impressions, particularly when considering judgements of personality traits and emotions. Extending Speelmeyer's (2024) study on trait judgements, this study examined emotion judgements and aimed to investigate how facial expression and tone of voice influence children's ratings of valence (positivity) and arousal (energy) – and whether anxiety symptoms moderate these effects. We predicted that participants would judge congruent cues (i.e. happy face with happy voice) as higher in valence and arousal levels than incongruent cues (i.e. happy face with angry voice), and that anxiety would influence these relationships. 45 children aged 4- to 13-years-old completed a survey comprising 32 multimodal face-voice clips (four emotions: happy, sad, angry, neutral) and 16 single-mode trials (face-only and voice-only). After each clip, children rated valence and arousal levels on 5-point Likert scales. Parents simultaneously completed the Spence Children's Anxiety Scale (parent version). Two repeated-measures ANOVAs tested the effects of facial and vocal emotion on valence and arousal, with follow-up models adding anxiety domains as a between subjects factor. Results indicate large main effects of facial and vocal emotions on both valence and arousal judgements, and no significant interactions or effects of overall or domain-specific anxiety. Meaning, children interpreted the facial and vocal cues independently, and anxiety did not have an influence. As no hypotheses were supported, Speelmeyer's findings on trait judgements cannot be extended to emotion judgements; therefore, implications and future directions are discussed.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Cognitive Psychology; Perception; Experimental Psychology; Social Psychology

ID: 2 | Method: Quantitative

Cognitive Biases in Cryptocurrency Investment: An Experimental Study of Unit Price Bias and Market Cap Insensitivity in Novices

Cryptocurrency is a digital currency known for extreme price fluctuations, attracting those seeking quick financial gains with little knowledge and experience, which leads to significant reliance on cognitive bias. Despite growing interest in cognitive biases within cryptocurrency markets, the specific roles of unit price bias (preference for low-priced tokens) and market capitalisation insensitivity (tendency to overlook supply in value assessments) remain underexplored. This experimental study investigated whether novice investors exhibited these biases, while also testing the potential mitigating effect of an information-based priming intervention and the moderating influence of individual differences. A total of 393 participants were recruited via Prolific and randomly assigned to primed ($n = 95$) or control ($n = 298$) conditions. Participants completed an online scenario-based experiment where they allocated funds across fictitious tokens systematically varying in unit price and market capitalisation, alongside completing assessments of socio-educational and dispositional traits. Results were analysed using repeated mixed ANOVAs and multiple regressions. Contrary to hypotheses, participants did not demonstrate unit price bias: allocations were highest to expensive tokens, lowest to moderate-priced tokens, and intermediate for cheap tokens. Market capitalisation insensitivity was consistently observed as predicted. Unexpectedly, priming did not reduce instances of either bias, despite participants demonstrating comprehension. Regarding individual differences, intuitive decision-making predicted greater unit price bias, while numerical reasoning predicted reduced market capitalisation insensitivity; other traits were unrelated. These findings challenge the robustness of unit price bias under controlled conditions and suggest future research should incorporate social media effects, real monetary risk, and varying investor expertise.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Individual Differences; Financial Psychology; Cyberpsychology

Prevalence of Anxiety Disorders in Adults with Spinal Cord Injury/Disorder: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis

Background: Anxiety disorders are common psychiatric conditions that impair quality of life and rehabilitation outcomes. Among adults with spinal cord injury or disorder (SCI/D), prevalence estimates remain inconsistent, often due to reliance on self-report symptom scales. This study aimed to synthesise prevalence estimates derived from diagnostic criteria and to examine methodological and clinical moderators. Methods: A systematic review and meta-analysis was conducted in accordance with PRISMA guidelines. Embase, Emcare, MEDLINE, PsycINFO, and supplementary sources were searched to April 2025. Eligible studies included adults (≥ 18 years) with medically confirmed SCI/D, reporting prevalence of anxiety disorders diagnosed via DSM, ICD, or structured clinician-administered interviews. Studies were critically appraised using the Joanna Briggs Institute (JBI) prevalence checklist. Proportions were meta-analysed using a random-effects model. Heterogeneity was assessed with I^2 and τ^2 , and moderator analyses examined diagnostic system, timeframe, study design, recruitment source, sampling method, sample size, gender distribution, mean age, and years since SCI/D. Results: Fourteen independent studies ($N = 33,668$) were included. The pooled prevalence of anxiety disorders was 9% (95% CI [6–13%]; prediction interval 2–32%). Considerable heterogeneity was observed ($I^2 = 99.2\%$). Moderator analyses identified years since injury as a significant predictor, explaining 67% of variance, though based on limited studies. No significant differences were found for diagnostic system, timeframe, design, recruitment, or demographic moderators. Conclusions: Approximately one in ten adults with SCI/D meet diagnostic criteria for an anxiety disorder, a rate exceeding that of the general population. Findings highlight the importance of early recognition, long-term monitoring, and further investigation of socio-contextual and clinical correlates. Future research should prioritise longitudinal designs, consistent diagnostic frameworks, and exploration of modifiable psychosocial factors to clarify trajectories of anxiety across the SCI/D lifespan.

Areas: Health Psychology; Clinical Psychology; Biological Psychology; Meta-Research

ID: 4 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Intentional connection: A Qualitative Analysis of Podcast Episodes Exploring Strengths Employed by Mothers in Same-Gender Relationships during Matrescence

The concept of matrescence understands motherhood as a developmental process during which women experience a range of changes, challenges, and growth. Mothers in same-gender relationships are underrepresented within matrescence research, and particularly within strengths-based research. This study used podcast episode transcripts as a qualitative data source, and aimed to explore the strengths, and perspectives that Australian mothers in same-gender relationships employ during matrescence. We identified a range of potentially suitable episodes, and developed a weighted scoring system to aid in final episode selection. The final sample consisted of 20 episodes, from four podcasts, and which featured 13 mothers in same-gender relationships. We analysed episode transcripts with reflexive thematic analysis, guided by a critical realist ontological framework, and contextualist epistemological framework. We generated five themes, and interpreted these with reference to feminist standpoint theory: Strong Vision for how I will Mother; Through Thick and Thin, we're Committed to Supporting Each Other; Queering Family and Household Dynamics; Fostering Connection and Community through Podcasting; and It's Important for me to Educate People about Queer Families. Our analysis indicated that Australian mothers in same-gender relationships demonstrate intentionality and openness when connecting with people in their personal lives, and broader communities. These findings may inform psychologists, midwives, and general practitioners about strengths to explore when working with queer mothers in same-gender relationships. Exploring such strengths with health providers may feel empowering for queer mothers in same-gender relationships.

Areas: Positive Psychology; Clinical Psychology; Community Psychology

ID: 5 | Method: Quantitative

Compassion in Teacher Training: A Serial Mediation Analysis of Variables Influencing the Student-Teacher Relationship

Exceeding levels of stress recorded in Australian educators poses concern for the wellbeing of teachers, and the subsequent outcomes for students, with research demonstrating a bidirectional relationship between teacher and student stress. Compassion-focused theory and the Science of Learning, an emerging paradigm combining psychology and neuroscience in education, have been applied to training programs focused on improving teacher awareness of emotion regulation, dysregulation and wellbeing. The current study aimed to explore whether teacher emotion regulation and wellbeing mediate the relationship between teacher perceptions of closeness with students and perceptions of student dysregulation. Pre-collected data from a compassion-focused theory training program was utilised, including a sample of 115 primary school students ($M = 9.7$, $SD = .54$) and teachers ($M = 40.7$, $SD = 3.68$) across Years 3, 4 and 5. Correlation tests revealed that cognitive reappraisal increased student wellbeing and suppression exhibited a negative association. Alternatively, teacher cognitive reappraisal demonstrated a positive association to student interaction and organisational wellbeing, and suppression demonstrated a positive association with workload wellbeing. Although the mediation analyses did not fully support the hypothesis, results indicated a large direct effect of closeness on emotion regulation, and emotion regulation on wellbeing, thus presenting the possibility of smaller mediational pathways. Such findings provide nuanced detail of the specific interactions between teacher wellbeing facets and emotion regulation. It is paramount for health professionals and researchers to explore the underlying regulatory processes targeted by compassion-focused training to understand the bidirectional relationship of emotion regulation and wellbeing between teachers and students.

Areas: Educational Psychology; Health Psychology

ID: 6 | Method: Quantitative

The relationship between Social Media Use and Online bullying on School Engagement in Adolescents: Examining the Mediating Role of Anxiety

Adolescents today navigate schooling within highly digitalised environments, where social media use and online bullying is prevalent and increasingly becoming recognised as risk factors for wellbeing. Although both have been individually linked to adverse outcomes, their combined influence on school engagement remains underexplored. The current study examined whether social media use and online bullying predicted lower school engagement among Australian adolescents, and whether anxiety mediated these relationships. Participants were 57,998 students in Grades 7-12 (ages 11-18) who completed the 2025 Resilience Survey. Measures included single-item self-reports of social media use and experiences of online bullying, a latent factor score for school engagement and a validated two-item scale of anxiety. A custom-built mediation model tested direct and indirect pathways, controlling for gender and socioeconomic status (SES). Results indicated that both social media use and online bullying independently predicted lower school engagement, with anxiety emerging as a significant mediator. Gender-based analyses revealed more pronounced effects for females, whereas SES showed no significant associations. The model explained 13% of variance in school engagement, a proportion consistent with large-scale research, suggesting modest but meaningful effects. These findings support prior literature and attentional control theory, indicating that digital stressors heighten anxiety and, in turn, diminish attentional resources essential for engagement. Further, results provide a rationale for school-based interventions that integrate mental health support with digital literacy education to promote resilience and sustain school engagement in adolescence. Keywords: social media use, online bullying, school engagement, anxiety, adolescence

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Educational Psychology; Learning & Behaviour; Cyberpsychology

ID: 7 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Transitioning to Online Learning and Teaching: An Assessment of the Impacts of COVID-19 on Australian Tertiary Educators

Background: The COVID-19 pandemic brought about a dramatic shift in tertiary education moving from face-to-face to online delivery negatively affecting pedagogical practice, increasing workloads and generating poor teacher wellbeing outcomes. Aims: This study explores tertiary educators' experiences during and after the pandemic looking at short- and long-term effects both at individual and organisational levels seeking to inform future policy and pedagogical practice. Method: Eleven higher education academics participated in semi-structured interviews exploring three key pandemic phases (March-June 2020; August 2020-October 2021; November 2021-present). Interviews were transcribed and analysed using reflexive thematic analysis within a critical-realist paradigm. Results: Five themes were developed: 1) Experiences of Teaching Modalities, 2) Workplace Conditions and Institutional Support, 3) Pedagogical Disruption, 4) The Emotional and Psychological Journey, and 5) Institutional Policies and Public-Health Imperatives. Conclusions: Findings indicate the importance of resilience and adaptability skills of educators and the greater need for research and interventions targeting tertiary institutional support, online teaching delivery, and contingency planning especially in crisis events. The pandemic amplified existing strains in higher education, and this study establishes the importance of prioritising teacher wellbeing and institutional agency in creating a sustainable, robust workplace.

Areas: Social Psychology; Educational Psychology; Health Psychology; Organisational Psychology; Cyberpsychology

Barriers and Facilitators Influencing Access to Tertiary Pain Management Clinics in Australia: A Quantitative study

Chronic pain is a significant issue in Australia. While integrated pain care is considered a highly effective pain management approach, few individuals living with chronic pain can access such care. Identifying access barriers and facilitators to pain management clinics (PMC), where such care is often provided, is essential for effective pain management. However, research has either not exclusively focused on access barriers and facilitators to PMCs, has explored PMCs in non-Australian contexts or is qualitative in nature. Built environment, another factor influencing healthcare access, is also under-explored in PMCs. Therefore, the study aims to identify (1) the most influential barriers and facilitators affecting access to Tertiary Pain Management Clinic (TPMC), (2) the most important built environment factors in facilitating access to TPMC. 90 participants including 62 individuals with chronic pain, 15 family members and/or carers of individuals with chronic pain and 13 healthcare providers with chronic pain management experience completed a cross-sectional survey involving close-ended questions based on the Levesque's Access to Healthcare (2013) and Sadek and Willis (2019) frameworks. Results showed that most participants lacked awareness about TPMC. Availability & accommodation was a more influential barrier domain than acceptability. No statistically significant differences were found between facilitator domain ratings. Supportive social environment and comfort, accessibility & safety domains were more important built environment factors than control over the environment and extra services, navigation & support design domains. These results can guide interventions and policies for improving access to TPMC and address the chronic pain burden in Australia.

Areas: Health Psychology; Public Health

The Moral Repetition Effect: The Role of Emotion and Belief in a Just World

Repeated exposure to moral wrongdoing is common across social media, raising concern about how repetition shapes moral judgement. Prior research in the United States and United Kingdom shows that encountering the same moral violation multiple times reduces its perceived unethicity, a phenomenon termed the moral repetition effect. Belief in a just world for others (BJW-other) has been proposed to play a role in this effect but has never been experimentally tested. This study replicated the moral repetition effect in an Australian sample, examining the mediating role of emotion and the moderating role of BJW-other. In a within-participants repeated-measures experiment, 301 Australian adults rated the unethicity of 28 moral transgression scenarios and the intensity of their own emotional responses. Half of the scenarios were previously viewed, and half were new. Participants also completed validated BJW-other and BJW-self scales. Linear mixed-effects and moderated mediation analyses showed that repetition produced a small but significant reduction in unethicity ratings, fully mediated by reduced emotional intensity. Contrary to predictions, BJW-other did not moderate the repetition–emotion pathway. Exploratory analyses found that the relationship between BJW-other and unethicity ratings varied across moral foundations. Findings extend evidence for the robustness and cross-national generalisability of the moral repetition effect, clarify the central role of emotion, and challenge the proposed BJW mechanism. Beyond its theoretical contributions, this study has implications for algorithm design, activism, and news communication because although repetition may enhance content reach and spread awareness, the findings suggest it dulls moral condemnation at the individual level. Keywords: moral judgement, repetition, emotion, belief in a just world, moral foundations

Areas: Experimental Psychology; Social Psychology; Cognitive Psychology

ID: 10 | Method: Quantitative

Exploring the Relationship Between E-Cigarette Use, Sleep, and Depression in Adolescents

Adolescent e-cigarette (EC) use has become an emerging public health concern, being linked with disrupted sleep and depression, amongst other adverse health and psychological outcomes. However, little is known about the interactive effect of EC use and sleep on adolescent mental health. The present study seeks to address this gap, exploring whether sleep mediates the relationship between adolescent EC use and depressive symptoms. A sample of 57,998 students aged 11-18 years ($M = 13.92$, $SD = 1.66$; 49.2% female, 50.8% male) completed an online cross-sectional survey, which included demographic measures, items relating to EC use, sleep duration and disturbances, as well as depression. Consistent with previous findings, EC use was positively associated with depressive symptoms. Mediation analyses further indicated that sleep duration and disturbances partially mediated this relationship. Notably, the effect of sleep disturbances was nearly three times greater than that of sleep duration, highlighting the unique importance of sleep quality in adolescent mental health. These cross-sectional results indicate that adolescents may be vulnerable to a cycle where EC use disrupts sleep which, in turn, contributes to heightened depressive symptoms. This cycle may further reinforce both sleep difficulties and continued EC use. These findings underscore the need for parents, educators, and health professionals to recognise the impact of EC use on adolescent wellbeing. Early identification and intervention may offer a pathway which addresses a disruptive cycle connecting EC use, poor sleep, and mental health challenges.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Health Psychology

ID: 11 | **Method:** Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Digital Divide in a Post-Pandemic Society: Exploring the Older Adult Experience when faced with Technology Post Covid-19

The Covid-19 pandemic disrupted the lives of older adults, accelerating technological progression and the need to digitally participate in society. This magnified inequalities faced by older adults in the digital divide. Research has primarily focused on older adult experiences during Covid-19, with post-pandemic research being scarce. Therefore, this study aims to explore the views and experiences of older adults with technology in a post-pandemic society. This allows for identification and evaluation of older adult's adaptation or struggle, highlighting prevalent areas for support advocacy. Twenty participants aged seventy or over, completed an in-person interview conducted by the student researcher, where their views and experiences were gathered and transcribed. Reflexive thematic analysis guided by a Critical Realist paradigm, was utilised to generate three themes from the data. These themes included, 'Keeping Up' with Technology, Adaptation through Necessity and, Dependency and Support. Results of the study were interpreted at face value and through the lens of the Digital Divide Theory, allowing for thorough understanding of digital participation and exclusion. Analysis indicated that older adults hold a dependency on others to maintain digital learning and 'keep up' with technology. However, catered, and accessible technological support services for older adults are scarce. Therefore, this thesis advocates for intervention strategizing and implementation, inclusive of accessible and catered technological support programs, peer support and, support worker roles.

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Health Psychology; Geriatric Psychology; Cyberpsychology

ID: 12 | Method: Quantitative

Mind-body Connection: Associations between Interoception, Mindfulness, Emotion Regulation & Anxiety

Interoception, one's ability to perceive and interpret internal body sensations, is a multifaceted process, research suggesting that poor interoception is linked to an increased susceptibility to anxiety. However, the direction of association between interoception and anxiety remains mixed, with the literature suggesting that increased interoception is associated with both increased and decreased anxiety (Brewer et al., 2021). A meta-analytic review suggests that one's attention and appraisal of interoceptive bodily signals is strongly connected to the association between interoception and anxiety (Clemente et al., 2024). Despite this, the role of mindfulness and emotion regulation (ER) techniques on this association remains relatively unexplored. The current study included survey responses from 206 participants utilising self-report measures of interoception, mindfulness, ER and anxiety to investigate the associations between interoception and anxiety, with mindfulness and maladaptive ER as potential mediators. Through correlation and serial mediation analyses, the results demonstrated a positive direct association between interoception and anxiety which was sequentially mediated by mindfulness and maladaptive ER. However, when accounting for all variables, the total effect of interoception on anxiety was negative; adaptive ER did not significantly mediate the association between interoception and anxiety. These results have both theoretical and clinical implications supporting the influence of mindfulness and ER as important therapeutic targets to ameliorate the effect of interoception on anxiety.

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Health Psychology; Cognitive Psychology; Positive Psychology

ID: 13 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Calculated hedonism and the creation of self-narratives: A reflexive thematic analysis of Australian university students' motivations and perspectives on binge-drinking

Binge drinking is a deeply embedded cultural norm within Australian culture and university contexts. Calculated hedonism considers how individuals pursue pleasure strategically, balancing enjoyment with control, and risk with responsibility, including in the context of binge drinking. While binge drinking can result in harm, it is also tied to storytelling, identity formation, and meaning making. Extending prior research, this study explored Australian university students' motivations and perspectives on binge drinking. A qualitative approach was adopted, examining how individuals make sense of their drinking, how it is experienced, narrated, and justified, and how meaning is assigned within a framework of calculated hedonism. Interview data from 15 Australian university students who had engaged in binge drinking was analysed using reflexive thematic analysis within a critical realist epistemology. Six themes and three subthemes were generated: 'Making informed choices between pleasure and potential harm' (subtheme: 'out of sight, out of mind'); 'binge drinking as planned and controlled'; 'alcohol as a social investment'; 'pressure to belong' (subtheme: 'pressure to drink the right way'); 'storytelling and identity making'; and 'changing people: evolving priorities and self-maturity' (subtheme: 'what really matters'). These themes demonstrated how students understood their drinking, balancing perceived harms against short- and long-term benefits relating to physiology, experience, safety, sociability, identity, and meaning. They also highlighted how students navigated these decisions through reflection, and how perspectives shifted with maturity and changing responsibilities. This study contributes to theoretical debates on youth consumption and practical initiatives to reduce alcohol-related harm.

Areas: Health Psychology; Social Psychology

ID: 14 | Method: Quantitative

Phishing Email Detection: The Role of Viewing Time and Cue Utilisation on Decision Styles

Phishing attacks are a growing threat in the modern day, with potential for severe financial and social harm. Previous literature has examined the detection of indicative phishing cues, focussing on the decision styles and their relationship with the ability to distinguish between genuine and phishing emails (sensitivity). Consequently, the information gathering component of decision making remains underexplored, limiting our understanding of whether cognitive decision making or time spent viewing emails predicts phishing victimisation. To examine the impact of time and cue utilisation on the ability to accurately identify phishing emails, the current study allocated time as a mediating variable on the relationship between decision styles (rational and intuitive), sensitivity, and decision criterion. Cue utilisation was allocated as a moderating factor within this mediating relationship. The sample consisted of 121 participants, who underwent the Email-Sorting Task, followed by an assessment of cue utilisation. The effect of decision styles on sensitivity was fully mediated by time spent viewing emails. Additionally, both decision styles significantly predicted sensitivity for individuals lower in cue utilisation, while the mediated pathway was not statistically significant for those higher in cue utilisation. These results suggest the potential benefit for training individuals to develop cue utilisation, as this would allow for both safe and efficient engagement with emails. Future studies should examine the user-specific parameters that could influence the success of the proposed cue-based training program.

Areas: Cyberpsychology; Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology

ID: 15 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

A Qualitative Exploration of Parent and Caregivers' Experiences Collaborating with Schools to Address School Refusal

School refusal, defined as emotionally driven non-attendance, is an increasing concern within Australia, affecting adolescents and their engagement with education. Existing literature has emphasised clinical and individual-level interventions, such as psychological therapy, while the role of parents and schools in addressing school refusal, particularly within the Australian education system, has been less studied. Guided by Bronfenbrenner's Bio-Ecological Theory of Human Development, this study explored parent and caregiver perspectives on their experiences of collaboration with schools in supporting their adolescent aged 13-16 experiencing school refusal. Using a qualitative open-ended survey, 33 parents and caregivers provided detailed accounts of their experiences. Data were analysed through reflexive thematic analysis, in which five key themes were generated: Child Mental Health and Wellbeing, School Environment as a Contributing Factor, School Responses and Institutional Barriers, Impacts on Families, and Alternative Education and Coping Pathways. Findings highlighted that school refusal is the result of a complex interaction of individual, relational, and systemic factors. The study emphasises the importance of schools adopting collaborative, flexible, and holistic approaches and offers insights for practical improvements to school responses to school refusal. Future research should extend this work by considering cultural aspects of school refusal and incorporating perspectives of adolescents and educators.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Educational Psychology

The Relationship Between Exposure to Negative Social Media Content and Daily Affect, and the Moderating Role of Depression

Australia's recent social media ban for under 16s has highlighted the need to better understand the potential harms of social media, including exposure to negative content. Despite widespread concern about social media's impact, existing research is predominantly cross-sectional and homogenises online risks (e.g., grouping content exposure with cyberbullying), obscuring the specific effects of negative content exposure. Therefore, this study focused directly on exposure to negative social media content and its relationship to daily affect. We also investigated whether depression symptoms moderate this relationship. Using a 7-day daily diary design, 70 Australian adolescents aged 14-17 completed baseline surveys assessing depression symptoms. Participants then completed daily surveys at 6pm for seven consecutive days, reporting exposure to negative social media content across multiple categories (excessive violence, graphic injury/death etc) and rating four positive affect (excited, enthusiastic, relaxed, peaceful) and four negative affect (anxious, irritated, sad, bored) items in relation to how they felt that day. I hypothesised that on days when participants were exposed to negative content, they would (1) report higher negative affect and lower positive affect and (2) depression symptoms would moderate these relationships, with stronger associations emerging among adolescents with higher depression symptom severity. Multi-linear regression models will be used to analyse the nested data structure of daily observations within individuals. Findings may inform targeted interventions for adolescents at heightened risk from negative social media experiences, particularly relevant as Australia implements new age-based social media restrictions.

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Developmental Psychology; Cyberpsychology; Social Psychology

Cue Utilisation as a Mediator of Driving Time and Performance: A Longitudinal Study With Experience as a Moderator

Cue utilisation—the cognitive process of identifying and applying environmental cues to inform decision-making—is positively associated with motor vehicle driving performance. However, few longitudinal studies have examined how cue utilisation is shaped by naturalistic fluctuations in driving activity over time. Recent changes in driving behaviour, partly due to pandemic restrictions and increased working from home, highlight the need to better understand this question. This study investigated whether changes in driving activity affect cue utilisation and subsequent driving performance. It was hypothesised that (1) changes in cue utilisation would mediate the relationship between changes in driving time and driving performance, and (2) years of driving experience would moderate the relationship between changes in driving time and cue utilisation, with weaker effects among more experienced drivers. Participants (N = 48) reported their weekly driving time and years of driving experience at Phase 1, then reported weekly driving hours via text message until Phase 2 (8–16 weeks later). At both phases, cue utilisation was measured using the driving edition of the EXPERTise 2.0 situational judgement tool, and driving performance was assessed with a simulator task. Moderated mediation analyses did not support the hypotheses, although increased cue utilisation significantly predicted improvements in lane-keeping. These findings suggest that small, naturalistic fluctuations in driving activity may not have immediate implications for cue utilisation or overall driving performance. Furthermore, whilst fine-grained aspects of driving performance (e.g., lane-keeping) appear more sensitive to changes in cue utilisation, broader aspects may require more targeted training to improve.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Human Factors

Enhancing Adolescent Athlete Well-being: A School-Based Intervention Targeting Psychological Flexibility and Value-Based Action

Adolescence is a period of heightened vulnerability to psychological distress, which may be amplified for young athletes navigating the demands of both sport and development. Psychological flexibility (PF) and value-based living are emerging processes for supporting well-being, yet evidence for effective school-based interventions remains mixed. This study evaluated "The Lion Roars", an eight-week program designed to enhance PF and valuing as a means of supporting well-being in adolescent athletes. The program was delivered through the school-sport context to maximise relevance and engagement. A pretest-posttest design was conducted with 48 adolescent athletes in Years 10-12, who completed measures of PF, valuing, and well-being before and after the intervention. It was hypothesised that participants would show increases in PF, valuing, and well-being; that changes in PF and valuing would be associated with changes in well-being; and that a significant proportion of participants would demonstrate reliable improvement in PF and valuing. Group-level analyses revealed no significant improvements across outcomes, yet an unexpected decrease in PF was observed. Hierarchical multiple regression appeared to provide partial support for associations between changes in PF and valuing with changes in well-being, though interpretation was complicated by the insignificant nature of the other findings. Individual-level analyses demonstrated that reliable improvement in PF and valuing was infrequent. Results suggest that, while feasible to deliver, "The Lion Roars" did not achieve its intended effects under the conditions tested. Findings highlight the challenges of implementing school-based mental-health interventions, emphasise the importance of contextual factors, and provide guidance for refining future programs. Key words: adolescents, athletes, psychological flexibility, valuing, well-being

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Sport & Exercise Psychology

ID: 19 | Method: Quantitative

Understanding Interpersonal Trust and Information Disclosure in Social and Professional Interactions

Adult grooming faces societal scepticism, lacks legal recognition, and is under-researched. This gap in understanding means vulnerable individuals remain at risk, despite evidence that, like children, vulnerable adults can also be groomed for abuse. This study aimed to provide insight into the factors influencing early-stage adult grooming through investigating the influence of trustee disposition and context on trust development and information disclosure. Using a mixed experimental design, participants (N = 135) were randomly assigned to one of two conditions (prosocial, antisocial) and presented with three vignettes (workplace, sports, and university), all depicting an interaction involving a power-imbalanced relationship. Scores were obtained regarding the perceived trustworthiness of the individual in power, the likelihood that the individual of lesser power would disclose personal information, and participants' own propensity to trust. Results found that prosocial individuals were more likely to be perceived as trustworthy and elicit information disclosure compared to antisocial individuals. Furthermore, individuals in the workplace were perceived as the least trustworthy and the least likely to elicit information disclosure, compared to both those in sports and university contexts. Lastly, it was found that participants' propensity to trust was positively correlated with trust and information disclosure scores. This study provides insight into contextual, relational, and personal factors that influence adult grooming, filling a gap in the literature and having the potential to begin to inform real-world contexts such as education, prevention, and policy.

Areas: Social Psychology; Forensic Psychology; Individual Differences

Divine Forgiveness and Sin: A Study of a Religious Sample

Forgiveness research has been a field of study within a psychological context for a few decades, with the majority of that research being focussed on interpersonal and self-forgiveness. By contrast, divine forgiveness has been under researched relative to the field as a whole, in theory it is practically similar to interpersonal forgiveness, with a divine being taking the place of the transgressed party. However, there are some differences, the primary one being that reconciliation is considered a necessary part of divine forgiveness, placing more emphasis on reconciliatory behaviour from both the individual and the divine being. This study aimed to build on research that quantified divine forgiveness by investigating the relationship between divine forgiveness and sin within a religious sample. This was done through a cross-sectional study, measuring participants' experience of divine forgiveness, perceptions of sin frequency and magnitude, behavioural sin, fear of sin and God image. It was hypothesised that divine forgiveness would have a positive correlation with perceptions of sin magnitude and would have a correlation with perceptions of sin frequency, and behavioural sin. Additionally, it was hypothesised that God image and fear of sin would moderate these relationships. A sample of 160 religious participants, from primarily Christian backgrounds were surveyed, with results indicating a negative correlation between divine forgiveness and all three measures of sin. Additionally, it was found that the relationships between divine forgiveness and perceptions of sin frequency and behavioural sin were moderated by God image. Specifically, that at higher levels of benevolent God image and lower levels of authoritarian God image, the observed negative correlations between divine forgiveness and sin frequency were stronger. These findings provide evidence for a practical relationship between divine forgiveness and sin, as well as providing evidence for the importance of an individual's perceptions of their God's attributes in forming this relationship.

Areas: Human Factors; Personality Psychology; Cultural Psychology; Social Psychology

Performance Over Time: The Effects of an Automated Facial Recognition System on Human Face Matching

Unfamiliar face matching is required in many applied settings to verify identities for security purposes and the prevention of crime. However, it is quite an error-prone task. Consequently, many applied settings such as airports use Automated Facial Recognition Systems (AFRS) as decision aids. While prior research has investigated time on task effects and simulated AFRS decision aid effects independently, both have not been studied together. Therefore, this present study aimed investigate how having an AFRS can as a decision aid can affect face matching performance in a longer face matching task in comparison to a control group with no aid. Participants (n = 118) in the study were randomly allocated into either the AFRS or control condition in which they completed the Kent Face Matching Test, divided into four Blocks. In the AFRS condition participants made two decisions per trial, they second after seeing the decision of a simulated AFRS with a 90% accuracy. Accuracy was the highest in the aided AFRS decision phase and increased from Block 1 to 4. Surprisingly, a similar pattern was observed in the unaided decision phase. Contrastingly, performance in the control condition remained stable across Blocks. Further analyses were conducted using Signal Detection Theory. An analysis of criterion showed an increasing response bias from Block 1 to 4, in all conditions. On the other hand, sensitivity remained unchanged. These findings have implications for understanding human-automation teaming in face matching tasks and decision-making in applied settings where face matching is done for an extended period of time.

Areas: Experimental Psychology; Human Factors; Cognitive Psychology; Applied Psychology; Forensic Psychology

Get Even or Get Mad: How effective is revenge? It depends on your perspective

Revenge and anger have been framed as malevolent responses to interpersonal transgressions. However, emerging research suggests that anger may serve as a more constructive alternative to revenge in relational contexts. The present study examined differences between anger across interpersonal (willingness to reconcile and trust), communicative (strength, moral criticism, moral change) and fairness (perceived fairness) outcomes, to determine whether one response proves more constructive for the self and relationship. The study also considered whether perspective, adopting the role of victim versus transgressor, moderated these effects. A 2 X 2 between-subjects experimental design (N=184) was employed, manipulating response type (anger and revenge) and perspective (victim and transgressor). It was hypothesised that anger would yield more constructive effects than revenge on interpersonal and fairness variables, though differences on communicative outcomes were less clear. Additionally, it was unclear if differences between perspectives would emerge across all measures. An interaction between response and perspective was anticipated for interpersonal and fairness outcomes, while expectations for communicative outcomes remained exploratory. Results indicated that anger produced greater positive effects on willingness to reconcile, fairness, perceived strength, and moral change, whereas trust and moral criticism were non-significant. Transgressors generally reported more positive outcomes across all dependent variable's measures, apart from trust. Additionally, it was found that perspective indeed had moderating effects on response type for willingness to reconcile. These findings contribute to understanding the distinct functions of anger and revenge and the influence of perspectives, highlighting anger's potential as a constructive alternative to revenge within close relationships. Keywords: revenge, anger, interpersonal transgressions, perspective, reconciliation

Areas: Social Psychology; Clinical Psychology; Experimental Psychology

Between Pride and Piety: Religious Narcissism and the Moral Experience of Divine Forgiveness

Divine forgiveness has been central to religious practices for many years, yet it has been widely unresearched in relation to other psychological and personality correlates, particularly narcissism. Whilst existing literature highlights the devout experiences of religious narcissists little is known about how they understand divine forgiveness. This thesis examined whether religious narcissists differ from religious non-narcissists in their experience of divine forgiveness and moral foundations. A total of 166 participants completed measures of narcissism (NPI-16), divine forgiveness (DFQ), religiosity (DUREL), moral foundations (MFQ-20) and self-deceptive enhancement and impression management (BIDR). A latent profile analysis revealed two distinct classes: religious narcissists and religious non-narcissists. Regression analyses showed that no group differences emerged in self-reported divine forgiveness. However, class membership significantly predicted moral foundation endorsement, with religious non-narcissists reporting stronger fairness and harm concerns. These findings suggest that while religious narcissists and religious non-narcissists report divine forgiveness similarly, they diverge within their moral orientations, which allows them to have different experiences of divine forgiveness. The results highlight the importance of considering personality differences in understanding the moral dimensions of divine forgiveness in identifying and exploring religious narcissists. This study contributes to psychology of religion by exploring the nuanced role of narcissism in shaping the intersection between morality, religiosity and divine forgiveness.

Areas: Individual Differences; Personality Psychology

ID: 24 | Method: Quantitative

Emotion regulation effort: does depression moderate the relationship between effort and affect?

Investing effort into emotion regulation is seemingly beneficial for people, as it can help an individual shift their emotions as desired. Despite its benefits, people are reluctant to invest this effort. Emotion regulation is an important aspect of psychological functioning (John & Gross, 2004); however, our understanding of whether regulation effort can predict changes in positive and negative affect is limited. Furthermore, it is empirically unknown whether effort in emotion regulation is beneficial to some but harmful to others. Here, we aim to understand the relationship between regulation effort and momentary affect, and if depression symptoms moderate this relationship. Over 7 days, we used experience-sampling surveys to measure participants (N = 233) momentary positive and negative affect, how much effort they put into prohedonic emotion regulation, in addition to their level of depression symptoms (measured once at baseline). Contrary to our hypotheses, we found that regulation effort was not a significant predictor of positive or negative affect. However, depression symptoms did moderate the relationship between regulation effort and positive affect. These findings indicate that people who had higher levels of depression symptoms benefited from investing effort into emotion regulation, as it significantly increased their levels of positive affect. Our unexpected findings substantiate the role of effort in interventions that require and encourage regulation effort, such as cognitive behavioural therapy. Keywords: emotion regulation, regulation effort, depression, experience-sampling methodology

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Personality Psychology

ID: 25 | Method: Qualitative (Content Analysis)

I'm going to run out soon, what then? A content analysis of people's online discussions about their experiences of Menopause Hormone Therapy shortages

Menopause, preceded by a transitional phase known as perimenopause, is a moment in time when individuals assigned female sex at birth have not menstruated for 12 months, often occurring in middle adulthood. Both phases are associated with a variety of physical and psychological symptoms. Globally, Menopause Hormone Therapy (MHT) is an effective pharmaceutical treatment for menopause-related symptoms. However, in recent years, shortages of this medication have adversely affected people's ability to access and maintain their MHT regime. The current study aimed to explore people's online discussions about their experiences of MHT shortages on Reddit. Using the Python program, posts made between X and Y discussing the MHT shortage were collected from a menopause subreddit and analysed using qualitative content analysis. One-hundred and twenty-eight posts from 117 posters were summarised in four categories: General Shortage Discussion, Behavioural Consequences, Health Consequences and General Consequences. The findings highlight the challenges people face because of shortages, including deterioration in physical, psychological and social health, as well as the need for treatment and lifestyle adjustments. Furthermore, the online accounts of MHT shortages demonstrated how people sought support and advice from others regarding the shortages. These findings may be able to guide appropriate education and support for people experiencing menopause who need to navigate MHT shortages.

Areas: Health Psychology; Cyberpsychology

ID: 26 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

'What's Perimenopause? Don't We Just Go Through Menopause?': A Reflexive Thematic Analysis of Australians' Knowledge Concerning Perimenopause and Menopause

Perimenopause and menopause are natural stages of ageing, marking the end of the reproductive lifespan, affecting all individuals assigned female at birth. Up to 80% of people experience symptoms that may include vasomotor disturbances and cognitive changes, and long-term health risks such as osteoporosis, cardiovascular disease and urogenital atrophy. Despite this prevalence, little is known about how Australians perceive menopause knowledge or the sources they rely on. Therefore, this study aimed to explore Australians' perceptions of menopause knowledge. Ninety-five publicly available submissions made to the Australian Senate Inquiry into Issues related to menopause and perimenopause were collected. Guided by a social constructionist framework, data were analysed using reflexive thematic analysis, incorporating inductive approaches informed by the Menopause Empowerment Model. Four themes were generated: (1) Insufficient knowledge and preparation for perimenopause and menopause, (2) Contributors to insufficient knowledge, (3) Consequences of insufficient knowledge, and (4) Diverse ways to improve knowledge. Findings highlighted that insufficient menopause knowledge is a systemic issue, not an individual failing. People described that limited awareness, perceived inadequate training for healthcare professionals, and social stigma contributed to them being dismissed or misdiagnosed, and forced them to self-educate. People's contributions also revealed possible pathways for reform. They emphasised the need for evidence-based resources, education reform, and broader public awareness. Ultimately, addressing these gaps is critical to improving health literacy and wellbeing across the lifespan.

Areas: Health Psychology

ID: 27 | **Method:** Quantitative

Tactical breathing as a recovery method for mental and physical fatigue induced by virtual reality exergaming

Limited research has explored the use of breathing techniques, such as box breathing, to aid recovery after mental and physical exertion in virtual reality (VR). Box breathing is a controlled breathing technique that helps regulate stress, improve focus, reduce physiological arousal, and enhance cognitive recovery. This study examined whether box breathing could help restore vigilance back to baseline levels after VR exposure. Twenty-three participants completed the Sustained Attention to Response Task (SART) before a 40-minute VR exergaming session playing Beat Saber. After VR exposure, the SART was repeated, followed by guided box breathing, and a final SART assessment post-intervention. Measures of fatigue demonstrated that VR exposure was physically and cognitively exhausting, evidenced by decreases in eye convergence and moderate workload scores. Inverse efficiency scores derived from the SART indicated significant differences across time points. Post hoc analyses revealed a significant decline from pre- to post-VR, but no significant changes post-intervention, suggesting that box breathing may not aid recovery. These preliminary findings suggest that box breathing may not effectively support the recovery of vigilance performance after short-term VR exposure. Further research with physiological monitoring is needed to better understand the effects of box breathing and its potential role in recovering from VR fatigue. Keywords: virtual reality, box breathing, recovery, fatigue, exertion

Areas: Experimental Psychology; Cyberpsychology; Cognitive Psychology

ID: 28 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

A Qualitative Study of the Definition of Evidence in Psychology: Implications for Teaching and Learning

In 2025, the Australian Psychology Accreditation Council proposed changes to accreditation guidelines, shifting the focus of psychology education from 'psychology as a science-based discipline using an evidence-based approach' to being informed by 'diverse ways of knowing'. Minimal inquiry into how psychology educators define evidence exists in recent academic literature, despite being directly responsible for ensuring undergraduate and postgraduate psychology students graduate with sufficient skills, knowledge, abilities and competencies. The present study, therefore, aimed to answer the research question "How do Australian psychology educators define evidence in psychology?" Eleven undergraduate psychology educators were recruited from one psychology school in Australia. Participants discussed the topic of evidence in psychology through open-ended interviews over Zoom. Reflexive thematic analysis was employed to analyse interview transcripts from the 11 interviews generating six themes: Evidence is Ambiguous, Evidence and Academic Research, Evidence and the Human Element, Evidence and Other Ways of Knowing, Evidence Evaluation, and Laying the Groundwork. Findings provide insight into how psychology educators define evidence and the implications for undergraduate and postgraduate teaching and learning.

Areas: Meta-Research; Educational Psychology

ID: 29 | Method: Qualitative (Content Analysis)

When Dieting Backfires: A Qualitative Exploration of Reddit Users' Emotional and Moral Meaning-Making Around Setbacks and Perceived Failure

Dieting is commonly promoted as a means of achieving better health, yet many individuals experience weight regain following restrictive practices. While weight cycling and dieting “failure” are well-documented, there has been limited exploration of how people interpret and communicate these experiences within online communities. The present study therefore asked “How do Reddit users articulate and negotiate the emotional and moral dimensions of dieting setbacks and perceived failure?”. A total of 965 original posts from the subreddit r/loseit were collected in March 2025 and analysed using qualitative content analysis, informed by a biopsychosociocultural framework. From 894 final coded posts, seven overarching categories were identified: Surveillance & Internalisation, Self-Regulation Outside Formal Models, Psychological Toll of Weight Management, Body Image & Identity Conflict, Moralisation of Eating Behaviour, Locus of Control, and Adaptive Reframing. Findings demonstrate how users construct dieting setbacks as not only personal lapses but also moral and identity burdens, situated within communal narratives of accountability and support. Posts revealed the emotional strain of repeated restriction and weight regain, strategies of resistance and disruption, and ambivalent positioning of responsibility between internal and external factors. These insights highlight the psychological and moral complexity of dieting experiences in digital contexts, offering a more rounded understanding of weight regain that extends beyond biomedical models. This study contributes to health psychology by showing how online communities function as key spaces of meaning-making, where personal struggles with weight are negotiated within broader sociocultural contexts of morality, health, and identity.

Areas: Health Psychology; Cyberpsychology

Psychosocial Safety Climate and Happiness: A Longitudinal Population-based Study

Psychosocial safety climate (PSC) is a well-established multilevel framework for predicting, measuring and evaluating the psychosocial factors in the work environment that shape employee well-being. However, its relationship with specific emotional states, such as happiness, remains underexplored. With over half of the global workforce facing well-being challenges, this gap highlights a key opportunity to investigate the broader mechanisms influencing individuals' emotional experiences at work. Drawing on self-determination theory and the job demands-resources model of burnout, the present study examines how PSC influences employee happiness, focusing on the mediating roles of job demands and job resources. We hypothesised that both PSC and job resources would be positively associated with happiness, whereas job demands would be negatively associated with happiness. Further, we proposed that job demands and job resources would mediate the relationship between PSC and happiness. To test these hypotheses, we employed a longitudinal design using data from 1160 participants across three waves of the Australian Workplace Barometer project, spanning 11 years. Regression analyses revealed that both PSC and job resources were significantly and positively associated with happiness, while job demands showed no significant relationship. Additionally, job resources partially mediated the relationship between PSC and happiness. The results underscore the importance of PSC in fostering happiness among employees. These findings contribute to the growing body of research on happiness at work, advancing both theoretical frameworks and practical strategies for enhancing well-being in organisational settings. Keywords: Psychosocial Safety Climate (PSC), employee happiness, job demands, job resources

Areas: Applied Psychology; Organisational Psychology; Positive Psychology

Psychological Flexibility and Athletic Mindset: Examining the Relationship between Constructs of Athletic Goal Pursuit in Australian Competitive Athletes

The pursuit of valued competition-related goals can generate feelings of discomfort and distress amongst athletes. Psychological flexibility (PF) and mindset are similar constructs used to understand goal-striving in the face of discomfort; however, their relationship has not been previously investigated in competitive sporting contexts. This study explored the relationship between athletic PF - measured as acceptance, avoidance and harnessing - and mindset - measured as growth and fixed mindset - to clarify the role of mindset as a potential modifiable construct to facilitate PF and athletic goal-attainment under stress. Growth mindset was hypothesised to correlate with greater acceptance and harnessing and lower avoidance, and fixed mindset was predicted to correlate with greater avoidance and lower acceptance and harnessing. Participants (N = 204) were Australian adults who competed in sport at a recreational, sub-elite/semi-professional or elite/professional level. An online self-report survey measured acceptance, harnessing and avoidance using the Personalized Psychological Flexibility Inventory for Sport (PPFI-Sport), and growth and fixed mindset using the Conceptions of the Nature of Athletic Ability Questionnaire-2 (CNAAQ-2). Structural equation modelling of the relationships between acceptance, avoidance and harnessing, and growth and fixed mindset found marginal model fit to the data and no support for the hypothesised relationships. Interestingly, a significant negative relationship was found between fixed mindset and avoidance. Interpretation of study findings was, however, limited by measurement error identified within both instruments. This suggests the need for further refinement and revalidation of the PPFI-Sport and the CNAAQ-2 for use with Australian competitive athlete populations.

Areas: Sport & Exercise Psychology

ID: 32 | Method: Quantitative

Forensic Algorithms in the Courtroom: The Impact on Juror Decision-Making

Although forensic algorithms are increasingly utilised in courtrooms, little research has been conducted into investigating how algorithms impact juror evaluations of forensic expert testimony. The current study aims to examine how the use of algorithms in forensic evidence influences juror decision-making through measuring likelihood of defendant guilt judgements. An online experiment with a 2 x 3 mixed factorial design was conducted with 73 participants recruited from the first-year psychology student pool at the University of Adelaide. Participants were randomly assigned to an algorithm or human-based evidence condition. They then read fictional expert reports in three domains (fingerprint, firearm and facial recognition analysis), and provided pre- and post-evidence guilt ratings. It was predicted that the algorithm condition would show significantly smaller positive guilt changes compared to the human condition. Higher crime media exposure, machine heuristic scores and scientific reasoning ability were also predicted to have greater positive guilt changes. Instead, the results suggested that condition, machine heuristic scores, crime media exposure and scientific reasoning did not have statistically significant impacts on guilt change. Exploratory analysis found a significant effect of condition on guilt change when the facial recognition domain was removed from the data. These findings contribute to understanding how the general public responds to algorithmic forensic evidence, which has implications for communication of such evidence in Australian courtrooms.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Forensic Psychology

ID: 33 | Method: Qualitative (Reflexive Thematic Analysis)

The Experiences of Gender and Sexuality Diverse 'Lived Experience Workers' in Multidisciplinary Mental Health Services in Australia

There is a large disparity between the mental health experiences of gender and sexuality diverse individuals and the general population with significantly higher rates of psychological distress, deliberate self-harm, and suicidal ideation – and a higher rate of accessing mental health support. Despite this, research also shows that gender and sexuality diverse mental health care is generally inadequate. Lived experience work is a new but quickly emerging discipline in the mental health sector. Existing literature explores the effectiveness on service-user outcomes of this line of work, however, research on the workforce experiences of lived experience workers themselves is limited. Further, there is no such research that currently exists highlighting the experiences of gender and sexuality diverse individuals in lived experience roles. It would be reasonable to assume that gender and sexuality diverse lived experience workers would have a unique insight to share regarding their experiences in the lived experience role, and further, how their working role and identity exist in multidisciplinary mental health spaces. The present study aims to address this gap in the literature using a reflexive thematic analysis of qualitative data collected on the experiences of gender and sexuality diverse lived experience workers in multidisciplinary mental health workforces. Online surveys were completed by adults who are working in a lived experience role in Australia in a multidisciplinary team who also identify as gender and/or sexuality diverse (N=38).

Areas: LGBTQ+ Studies

Transparency in AI-assisted writing: Effects of disclosure on perceived credibility of scientific abstracts

With the release of ChatGPT in 2022, scientific researchers are often required to disclose the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems to generate text within research papers. However, there is little understanding as to whether these disclosure mandates impact perceptions of credibility within a scientific research context. This study aimed to investigate whether people's credibility assessments of scientific research abstracts were impacted by disclosing the use of AI to generate them. An online experiment was conducted with 56 participants recruited from SONA. Using a between-subjects design, participants were assigned to either an AI-disclosure condition or non-disclosure condition. Participants were asked to read 8 mock-scientific research abstracts (focussed on public health and climate change) and rate their perceived message credibility. Following this, participants in both conditions were asked a series of questions which measured their belief in the machine heuristic, as well as their scientific reasoning skills. We predicted that AI-disclosure would negatively impact participant's credibility assessments of the abstracts, and that the machine heuristic would moderate credibility assessments for participants in the disclosure condition. However, results indicated no significant effect of AI disclosure on message credibility assessments. Further analysis also showed that credibility assessments in the AI-disclosure condition were not moderated by the machine heuristic. However, results did indicate that greater belief in the machine heuristic was positively and significantly associated with higher message credibility scores across both conditions. This study highlights the need to further investigate the impact of AI-disclosure in across a broader range of scientific research areas, as well as further investigation into the role of the machine heuristic within academic research contexts.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Cyberpsychology

ID: 35 | **Method:** Quantitative

Boundary extension: The ultra-rapid scene processing error

Boundary extension is a memory error where people remember seeing more than what was viewed. It has been found to occur across various retention intervals with boundary extension elicited in 42ms and up to 48 hours later. What we do not know is if boundary extension changes from an immediate time point to a long-term time point. We hypothesised that boundary extension would occur at an immediate test and long-term test and the extent of boundary extension would increase after 10 minutes. Additionally, we expected no change in the direction of the errors made. We recruited 72 participants through Prolific and completed a semi-replication of Intraub and Dickinson's (2008) study. Participants memory of boundaries was tested after a 42ms mask and again after a 10-minute delay, using a within subjects design. The paradigm was updated as well, using only identical images, i.e. the angles of the images never changed. We found boundary extension to occur at both the immediate test and the long-term test, however there was no difference between both tests $t(68) = 1.12$, $p = .266$, $d = .14$, $BF_{01} = 4.15$. Additionally, there was a significant decrease in accuracy from the immediate test to the long-term test $t(68) = 2.08$, $p = .041$, $d = 0.25$. These results demonstrate boundary extension occurs so quickly that even testing participants' memories almost immediately still resulted in boundary extension errors. This casts doubt on the current multisource model and highlights what we think we see does not reflect reality.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology

ID: 36 | Method: Qualitative (Reflexive Thematic Analysis)

Lived Experience as Guidance: A Qualitative Study of Parental Advice for Craniosynostosis

Craniosynostosis, the premature fusion of one or more cranial sutures, presents complex medical, psychosocial, and caregiving challenges for affected families. Prior research has documented parent's experiences of navigating diagnosis and treatment, highlighting that they value connecting with other families to share insights and support. However, there is limited understanding of the practical and emotional guidance parents themselves would offer to others facing similar circumstances. To address this gap, the present study analysed pre-existing qualitative interview data from 22 parents using reflexive thematic analysis. Six themes were generated: (1) Stay Informed and Make Informed Choices, (2) Prepare for the Journey – Practically and Emotionally, (3) Build a Support Network, (4) Advocate with Confidence, (5) Care for Yourself Along the Way, and (6) Find Strength in Positivity and Growth. These findings identify condition specific advice and demonstrate how parents' experiential insights can complement clinical guidance. In particular, they address unmet needs for relevant, meaningful practical information and psychosocial support. The study highlights the importance of integrating parental advice into family-centred care, particularly via structured resources and peer-support initiatives offered at the point of diagnosis. Incorporating parents' insights into care practices ensures families have access to practical and emotional guidance grounded in lived experience.

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Health Psychology

ID: 37 | Method: Quantitative

The impact of childhood hearing loss on adolescent academic and psychosocial outcomes

Objective: Research has consistently identified an impact of severe childhood hearing loss on several developmental outcomes, including academic achievement and psychosocial wellbeing in childhood and into adolescence. Research on the impact of mild childhood hearing loss on these outcomes has been inconsistent, particularly regarding its longitudinal impact. In this study, the researcher examined the association between hearing loss at age 11-12 years old and academic performance and psychosocial wellbeing at age 14-15 years old. Method: this prospective cohort study used data from the Baby cohort of the Longitudinal Study of Australian Children (n=729), linked to data from the Child Health Checkpoint, an additional wave of data collection to the LSAC using biophysical measures such as a hearing test, and the National Assessment Program – Literacy and Numeracy (NAPLAN), a standardised measure of academic performance used in Australia in Year 9 (ages 14-15). Children with mild hearing loss in one or both ears were compared to children with normal hearing on all 5 domains assessed in the year 9 NAPLAN, and had their psychosocial wellbeing compared using scores on a self-reported Strengths and Difficulties Questionnaire (SDQ) completed at age 14-15. Results: Childhood mild hearing loss was significantly associated with being categorised as having borderline to abnormal psychosocial wellbeing on the SDQ in adolescence, OR=1.97, 95% CI [1.37, 2.84]. Hearing loss was not significantly associated with academic performance on any of the five domains. Discussion: An understanding of the effect of mild hearing loss in childhood on psychosocial wellbeing and academic performance may aid in understanding whether routine screening for hearing loss during childhood would be useful in reducing the effect of mild hearing loss during adolescence.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Public Health

Exploring Persons With Disabilities Psychological Preparedness for Extreme Weather Events: A Systematic Review and Meta-Synthesis of Qualitative Literature

Climate change increases the frequency and intensity of extreme weather events (EWEs) and disproportionately impacts mental health, particularly among persons with disabilities (PwDs) (Charlson et al., 2021; IPCC, 2023). Despite this threat, challenges faced by PwDs during EWEs remains underexplored, as mitigation strategies often exclude them (Nguyen-Trung et al., 2025) and neglect psychological preparedness (Boylan & Lawrence, 2020). In order to understand what is already known, this systematic review and meta-synthesis explored how PwDs psychologically prepare for EWEs. In accordance with the Joanna Briggs Institute, a meta-aggregative methodology was adopted. Peer-reviewed qualitative literature was obtained from four databases, a total of 12 studies and 339 participants were included in the review. The studies yielded 10 categories and four synthesised findings: (1) PwDs psychologically prepare in diverse ways, (2) internal barriers limit psychological preparedness, (3) insufficient training and resources limit psychological preparedness, and (4) adequate support and training foster psychological preparedness. Collectively, the findings highlight that PwDs use a range of strategies to psychologically prepare, which can sometimes enhance preparedness and, in other cases, hinder it. PwDs are often not equipped with the appropriate resources or training and are constrained by systemic barriers. However, when suitable resources are provided, PwDs report positive experiences of psychological preparedness. These results underscore the need for more individualised policies that enable PwDs to psychologically prepare for EWEs. Such policies should be adaptable, accessible, and grounded in a shift from a deficit-based view of disability towards an empowerment-focused approach. This will ensure that future planning promotes independence and recognises that PwDs are inherently adaptive and resilient.

Areas: Health Psychology; Community Psychology; Meta-Research

ID: 39 | **Method:** Mixed-Methods (Thematic Analysis)

An Exploration of the Impact of Attention on Decision-Making Under Threat: A Mixed-Methods Study in Virtual Reality

Virtual Reality (VR) is a technology that is increasingly being used to explore issues in applied psychology. Clinical applications using VR interventions are also gaining traction as the possibilities that a safe immersive environment can provide to practitioners is becoming better understood. This study examines how the experience of emotions influences capacity to control attention when faced with threat. Current research into threat and decision making in VR has shown that subjective fear determines outcomes and personality measures cannot predict performance. To address this gap, the present study explores the field of VR threat assessment by investigating how attentional control, anxiety and interoceptive awareness may mediate threat response. Furthermore, it explores whether subjective fear and attentional disengagement moderate this relationship. This research utilised a mixed-methods study design incorporating measures of individual differences, a dot-probe task to evaluate attentional processing to threatening stimuli, a VR simulation exposing participants to escalating threat scenarios, and a post-VR semi-structured interview. Participants were assigned to a behavioural grouping based on their behaviour in the VR simulation. It is hypothesised that participants who complete the simulation will exhibit high attentional control and be able to disengage from threat more rapidly. The results of this study may provide insight into predicting human responses to threat and further inform VR-based clinical interventions.

Areas: Applied Psychology; Individual Differences; Virtual Reality applications

Emotion-Induced Blindness in Childhood: An Exploratory Study

Emotion-induced blindness (EIB) refers to the reduced awareness of items that appear shortly after an emotionally arousing and irrelevant stimulus. While previous studies have focused on adults, this cross-sectional study is the first to explore the development of EIB in children. The present study aimed to determine whether children could effectively engage with the EIB task and assessed whether positive and negative emotional distractor images impaired their awareness of a target image. We examined whether the effect was stronger for either type of distractor and investigated any age-related differences in task performance. Additionally, we sought to identify which images were most effective at capturing attention in children, as many high-arousal images used in adult studies are inappropriate for younger audiences. A total of 112 children aged 5 to 12 participated in the study. We employed a rapid serial visual presentation (RSVP) paradigm, in which a target image was rotated to the left or right. In some RSVP trials, this target was preceded by an emotionally significant distractor image, while in others, no distractor image was shown. We measured the accuracy of the children in identifying the rotation of the target image. The results indicated that children had the attentional capacity to engage with the task, achieving a baseline grand mean accuracy of 52.25%. We found an interaction between positive and negative distractor images at 300 and 500ms, and that this relationship was also affected by age grouping. The most effective negative image in capturing attention was 'Dog Bite', while 'Happy Dog' was the most effective positive image. Overall, the results suggest that emotionally distracting images do impair children's awareness of target images presented in close succession. Specifically, close-up images depicting imminent threats and happy, smiling faces of animals were particularly effective in producing this effect.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Cognitive Psychology

ID: 41 | Method: Mixed-Methods (Content Analysis)

Young People's Perceptions of Trust, Benefits, and Challenges of Artificial Intelligence in Mental Health Settings: A Mixed-Methods Study of Young Australians

Mental health systems worldwide are increasingly overwhelmed, with shortages of professionals and barriers to access making innovative solutions a public health priority. Artificial Intelligence (AI) has been introduced into this space, both through purpose-built mental health applications and general generative tools. To date, there is insufficient knowledge in this fast-developing field on how young people perceive the use of AI in mental health. This study investigated young people's (18-24 years) perceptions of AI in mental health, focusing on trust, benefits, and challenges. Two hypotheses were tested: (1) frequent AI use is associated with more positive attitudes toward AI, and (2) frequent AI use, combined with positive attitudes, is a predictor of increased willingness to consider AI as a clinical tool. Two exploratory questions also guided the research: (1) What barriers do young people perceive when accessing traditional and AI-integrated services? and (2) What influences their willingness to use AI in these settings? A mixed-methods survey design was employed, with $n = 117$ participants for quantitative analysis and $n = 109$ for qualitative content analysis. Results showed that while frequent AI use was associated with more positive attitudes, it did not increase willingness to use AI in clinical contexts, and attitudes toward AI were the key predictor of willingness. Qualitative findings highlighted benefits such as accessibility and consistency, alongside limitations including privacy, empathy and quality, and ethical concerns. Practical implications include embedding ethical safeguards, prioritising trust-building frameworks, and aligning design with user needs to support responsible AI integration in mental health.

Areas: Clinical Psychology; Health Psychology

Impact of Disclosing an Aid's Reliability on Automation-Aided Performance

Over the past few decades, research has shown that effective human-automation collaboration depends on well calibrated trust in automated aids. Information transparency has been proposed as a design principle to foster appropriate trust and improve performance. Past research has manipulated reliability transparency through trial-by-trial confidence ratings. The present study examined whether disclosing an aid's overall reliability level influences operator performance. Sixty first-year undergraduates from the University of Adelaide were recruited to take part in a signal detection task where they assumed the role of a nuclear power plant operator, determining each trial whether the simulated system was in a safe or dangerous state. Participants completed the task both unaided and aided by a 93%-reliable aid, with reliability disclosure (known vs unknown) manipulated between groups. Results showed that performance on aided blocks was greater than on unaided blocks of trials. However, there was no difference in performance between the known and unknown conditions. This study further contributes to previous findings of automation use, suggesting that explicitly disclosing the reliability level of an aid alone may not be sufficient to calibrate trust and improve automation-aided performance.

Areas: Human Factors; Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology

Anatomical Correlates of Reinforcement Learning: White Matter Pathways Underlying Reward and Punishment Learning in Obesity

Reinforcement Learning (RL) concerns how people learn to repeat actions that maximise rewards (reward learning) or avoid actions leading to punishment (punishment learning). Despite evidence that these processes rely on functionally opposing corticostriatal circuitry, no study has examined whether this circuitry is anatomically distinct. This distinction is critical for understanding conditions such as obesity, in which impaired punishment learning observed in this population may result from disrupted neural mechanisms. Using Diffusion Tensor Imaging (DTI) and behavioural data, we aimed to determine whether reward and punishment learning are associated with distinct white matter pathways, and whether reduced white matter integrity in these pathways is associated with RL impairments in obesity. Participants aged 50-80 years (N = 751) completed a probabilistic RL task assessing general performance, reward, and punishment learning. Group differences in RL were examined between 231 normal-weight and 251 obese participants. MRI diffusion data were collected from a subsample of these participants (n = 72; 22 normal-weight, 19 obese), and whole-brain tract-based spatial statistics was employed to examine associations between white matter integrity and RL, as well as group differences by weight class. Obese participants demonstrated lower general RL performance than normal-weight participants, but this was non-significant after controlling for age, education and sex. No group differences were found in punishment learning. Whole-brain DTI analyses revealed no significant associations between white matter integrity and RL measures, nor differences between weight groups. These results suggest obesity might not be associated with deficits in overall punishment learning. Implications and directions for future research are discussed.

Areas: Biological Psychology; Cognitive Psychology; Learning & Behaviour; Geriatric Psychology

ID: 44 | **Method:** Qualitative (Content Analysis)

The Views and Experiences of Individuals Regarding Psychologists For Bariatric Surgery in the Australian Context: A Qualitative Content Analysis

Obesity has grown to epidemic proportions, with approximately 13% of adults globally being considered obese. Health burdens are linked to obesity, including type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease. Bariatric surgery is considered the gold standard intervention to treat obesity and related conditions, involving the rerouting or removal of sections of the stomach and small intestine to enable weight loss. There are several biopsychosocial implications of bariatric surgery, with mixed findings showing positive and negative outcomes after the procedure. Existing literature shows that psychological interventions may be effective in improving outcomes after bariatric surgery. However, there is limited research on the perspectives of individuals who have undergone this procedure on the use of psychologists for purposes related to bariatric surgery in Australia. To address this gap in the literature, the present study aimed to answer the research question: "What are the views and experiences of individuals who have undergone bariatric surgery regarding psychologists in the Australian context?" An online survey captured the responses of 191 participants, which were analysed using conventional qualitative content analysis. From the analysis, four overarching categories were developed: Psychologists Perceived as Useful, Psychologists Perceived as not Useful, Reasons for not Consulting a Psychologist, and Areas for Development in Bariatric Psychological Care. Findings of this study provide knowledge into the facilitators and barriers of psychological care within the bariatric surgery trajectory. Additionally, findings highlight areas in which multidisciplinary teams can improve to provide more tailored care to those undergoing bariatric surgery. Keywords: obesity, bariatric surgery, psychological care, health psychology

Areas: Health Psychology

Serial vs. Parallel Processing of Emotional Words under Visual and Phonological Working Memory Load: An Electroencephalography Study Using the Flanker Task

Psycholinguistic literature continues to be divided on whether words in sentences are processed serially or in parallel. Early studies supporting serial processing suggest that the lexical processing of a word can only be completed once the prior one is. However, recent studies have argued for parallel processing, where visual attention is shown to be spread over multiple words. The Eriksen flanker task with masked emotionally-valenced words and manipulations of visual and phonological working memory loads was employed to explore this debate. Parallel processing models predict that flanker words would influence processing, with such effects reduced under phonological working memory load but enhanced under visual working memory load. Serial processing models predict stronger processing of target words than flanker words, delayed under phonological working memory load and reduced under visual working memory load. Both models predict slower processing under visual working memory load due to reduced precision. Processing was measured using reaction times, error rates, and event-related potentials from 27 English-speaking participants. Behavioural results revealed minimal congruency effects with only visual working memory load producing a valence effect. Electroencephalography results showed early N200 interactions under control and visual working memory load, while a later P300 effect was found under phonological working memory load. These findings suggest that while behavioural data showed a lack of evidence for congruency, event-related potentials revealed valence-specific congruency effects, supporting the view that parallel processing of words can occur but is constrained by working memory load, highlighting the interaction between emotion, memory, and attention in shaping word processing. Keywords: Eriksen flanker task, working memory, reading, event-related potentials, emotion.

Areas: Biological Psychology; Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Psycholinguistics

Personality and attitudes toward AI as predictors of AI use among Australian workers and university students

The increased presence of generative artificial intelligence (GAI) tools has been widely observed in workplaces and education contexts, with the public launch of ChatGPT in late 2022, and GPT-4 in 2023, recognised as key inflection points. Despite rapid uptake, these tools remain controversial, and the psychological factors influencing adoption at the individual user level are underexplored. While attitudes toward technology are known to predict adoption, the role of individual differences such as personality traits in shaping both attitudes toward GAI and subsequent use is less clear. Existing research has produced mixed and context-specific findings, often examining narrow applications (e.g., interactive robots) or specific occupational groups (e.g., AI-assisted reviews for radiographers). The present study explores associations between personality traits, attitudes toward GAI, and use of GAI tools among a diverse sample of workers and university students. Specifically, it examines whether personality traits are associated with GAI tool use, whether they predict attitudes toward GAI, and whether attitudes are related to use. The potential for attitudes to mediate or moderate the personality–use relationship is also explored. Data were drawn from an online survey of 363 Australian adults ($n = 202$ workers, $n = 161$ students), who completed the Big Five Inventory–2 Short Form (BFI-2-S), the Attitudes Toward Artificial Intelligence Scale (ATTARI-12), and self-reports of GAI usage frequency across work and study settings. Planned analyses include regression, mediation, and moderation. By integrating personality, attitudinal, and behavioural measures, this study contributes to understanding the psychological factors underlying GAI adoption, with implications for effective and ethical implementation in professional and educational contexts.

Keywords: attitudes toward AI, generative artificial intelligence, personality traits, technology adoption, university students, workers

Areas: Personality Psychology; Individual Differences; Cyberpsychology; Applied Psychology

ID: 47 | Method: Qualitative (Content Analysis)

Death Anxiety and Attitudes and Beliefs about Death in Psychology Students at the University of Adelaide 2025

Death Anxiety is the fear one experiences due to being conscious of their mortality. Despite being a universal experience for individuals, the topic of death is considered taboo in Australian society. This qualitative study aims to address the gap in Australian literature regarding psychology students' death anxiety and attitudes and beliefs surrounding death. Data were collected via a qualitative survey consisting of the Death Anxiety Beliefs and Behaviour Scale (DABBS) (Menzies et al., 2022) and open-ended questions (n = 117). DABBS results are described, and qualitative content analysis applied to open ended survey content. The results indicated 43% of students' (n = 50) DABBS scores fell within the clinical range for death anxiety. The conventional qualitative content analysis yielded 6 overarching categories; ambivalence and barriers to engage in death work in psychology, death education absent from the curricula, death knowledge's relevance is dependent on context (i.e. area of psychology), students' death attitudes are unaffected from studying psychology, students' desire death education, and death anxiety experienced by students. The present study highlights the importance of including death education in the psychology curricula to support students interested in this area and encourage students to consider working in death related areas due to the recognised invisibility of psychologists in death and end-of-life care in Australia. The results emphasise the value of providing adequate support to diminish personal and educational barriers around death education as well as increasing students' competency and understanding in such areas.

Areas: Health Psychology

Predictors of public support for misinformation countermeasures on social media

This study examined the relationships between conspiracist ideation, actively open-minded thinking about evidence, misinformation exposure, and how these variables impact support for misinformation countermeasures. Participants (N = 450) were recruited from undergraduate statistics classes in 2024 and 2025. Participants first indicated which social media platforms they used, along with frequency and duration of use. For each platform participants indicated they used, they reported the frequency with which they encounter misinformation across a variety of topics (e.g., climate change, mental health, politics). Participants were then randomised to one of two misinformation labelling conditions (assume misinformation is labelled according to the status-quo vs. with perfect accuracy) before indicating their level of support for a variety of misinformation countermeasures. Participants also completed measures of conspiracist ideation and actively open-minded thinking about evidence. Conspiracist ideation was weakly positively correlated with misinformation exposure and moderately negatively correlated with support for countermeasures. Actively open-minded thinking about evidence was moderately negatively correlated with conspiracist ideation and moderately positively correlated with support for countermeasures. There was no effect of hypothetical misinformation labelling condition on support for misinformation countermeasures. We also found wide variation in self-reported misinformation exposure across different social media platforms (TikTok and Instagram highest, Discord lowest). These findings imply that when designing countermeasures for misinformation, they should be tailored to the social media platform and target trust and values rather than accuracy of identifying misinformation. As conspiratorial thinking is a barrier to support for misinformation, whereas actively open-minded thinking about evidence is a protective factor, targeting these may be highly relevant to effectively countering misinformation on social media.

Areas: Individual Differences; Cyberpsychology

How old do I look? The Role of Static vs. Dynamic Faces and Exposure Time in Age Estimation Accuracy

Age estimation in research involves estimating people's ages based off their appearance. This is essential in everyday life when you encounter new people for the first time as it can shape the way you perceive and interact with them, as well as in some legal settings such as eyewitness memory recall. To date, most research on age estimation is conducted by presenting participants with passport-style images of strangers' faces where they are required to respond with their estimated age with a 2-digit response. However, faces in the real world are often seen live and moving with changing expressions and different visibility of features. Current research doesn't fully capture the processes involved in age estimation in the real world with dynamic faces as it relies on static images. The purpose of this study was to directly compare age estimation across dynamic videos and static images to determine whether participants' ability to accurately estimate strangers ages was affected. Additionally, we also examined whether viewing duration influenced estimation accuracy. To examine this, we had participants estimate the ages of 30 strangers. Participants were randomly assigned to either the dynamic videos condition where they saw 30 videos of strangers' faces, 15 for 2 seconds and 15 for 5 seconds or the static images condition where this was replicated with photographs of faces. Results indicated that there was no effect detected between the stimuli type suggesting participant performance was not impacted by whether they saw dynamic videos or static images. Furthermore, an effect of encoding duration was detected whereby participants had better accuracy when estimating age after viewing the face for 5 seconds, compared to 2 seconds.

Areas: Applied Psychology; Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology

Degrading Trust: An Experimental Examination of how Misinformation Effects Spillover and Erode Specific and General Institutional Trust

Institutional trust is essential for democratic stability but is progressively diminishing worldwide. Misinformation exposure is argued to contribute to this decline, but evidence is limited. Most existing literature is correlational and examines existing associations between misinformation exposure and trust, limiting our ability to draw causal conclusions about the relationship. Moreover, studies often measure exposure through imprecise variables and employ unidimensional trust scales. Therefore, the current study used an experimental design to assess whether high misinformation media environments lead to trust spillover effects. That is, whether high misinformation environments causally reduce trust in unrelated, non-misinforming institutions (Government, Science, Public Health, Media). A representative sample of US adults ($N = 336$) viewed 48 headlines within a simulated social-media environment, with participants randomised to either a high misinformation (75% false; 25% true) or low misinformation (25% false; 75% true) environment. Participants provided their general trust (trust, mistrust, distrust) in institutions before and after viewing the headlines, indicated their trust in the sources present within the information environment, and completed measures of conspiracist ideation and intellectual humility. Participants exposed to a high misinformation environment had significantly lower trust in non-misinforming sources from the simulated environment ($p < .001$, $d = -0.82$) and lower general positive trust in institutions ($p < .001$, $d = -0.20$). These findings provide causal evidence for the potential for misinformation to have spillover effects and erode trust in non-misinforming sources and institutions, further highlighting the need to address misinformation and limit its spread.

Areas: Social Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Applied Psychology

ID: 51 | **Method:** Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Western Understandings of South Korea's 4B Movement Post-2024 U.S. Election – A Reflexive Thematic Analysis of Reddit Discourse

The 4B Movement (no [heterosexual] sexual relationships, no dating, no marriage, no childrearing) is a digital feminist movement that emerged in South Korea amid severe gender inequality. Whilst current literature examines the 4B Movement in Korea, and digital feminism in Asia and the U.S. more broadly, there is no current psychological research on the impacts of the 4B movement in the West following Trump's second term and the subsequent restrictions on women's rights. This thesis investigates how the 4B movement is being understood in Western contexts following the 2024 U.S. election, and its implications for contemporary feminism. Using a critical realist paradigm, a qualitative Reflexive Thematic Analysis was conducted on 28 subreddit threads to explore how individuals of diverse genders understand the movement. Four themes were generated: (1) How election results fuel gender divide; (2) Women's affective responses to feeling physically and emotionally unsafe; (3) How the 4B movement is being understood in the West; and (4) Tensions arising from appropriation vs adaptation with subthemes: Cross-cultural tensions between South Korea and the West and Intersectional tensions within Western feminism. Findings reveal that the 4B movement is a site for negotiating identity, safety, relationality, and resistance, amid sociopolitical unrest. Implications span clinical, health, and social psychology, suggesting that political trauma, gendered power dynamics, and systemic inequities are experienced as embodied psychological distress. Findings underscore the urgent need for intersectional, politically contextualised approaches in therapeutic models and broader psychological frameworks to better address emerging mental health crises in increasingly polarised societies.

Areas: Social Psychology

Associations between Adverse and Positive Childhood Experiences and Prosocial Behaviour in Early Adolescence.

Early adolescence is a developmentally formative period, marked by significant vulnerability for ongoing psychological difficulties. Past research shows that engaging in positive behaviours, including prosocial behaviour, during adolescence fosters coping skills and resilience which may help adolescents overcome challenges. Evidence suggests that childhood experiences may contribute to the development of adolescent prosocial behaviours, yet this relationship is underexplored, particularly in Australian samples. This study investigated the association between adverse and positive childhood experiences (from age 0-1 to 10-11) on prosocial behaviours of Australian early adolescents (age 12-13). It was hypothesised that adverse childhood experiences would be negatively associated with prosocial behaviours, and positive childhood experiences would be positively associated with prosocial behaviours when controlling for covariates. The influence of experiencing four or more adversities on later prosocial behaviour, and the potential moderating role of positive experiences on the relationship between adverse experiences and prosocial behaviours were also explored. Prospectively collected data from 753 participants from the Longitudinal Study of Australian Children were used to address these aims. Consistent with the hypotheses, regression analyses indicated that adverse childhood experiences were negatively, and positive childhood experiences were positively, associated with prosocial behaviours. Experiences of harsh parenting, parental substance use, co-parenting alliance, and contact with family were most strongly associated with prosocial behaviours. No evidence was found that positive experiences moderated the impact of adverse experiences. These findings emphasise the importance of interventions and family-based supports that promote positive experiences and address consequences of adverse experiences to encourage prosocial development in Australian adolescents.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Clinical Psychology

Stimulus familiarity enhances allocation of visual working memory resources

Visual working memory (VWM) is the system which temporarily maintains visual information for cognitive tasks. Research has focused on its limited capacity of 3-4 items, using change-detection paradigms that force participants to maximise its limit. However, in real-world settings, we rarely use our VWM to maximum capacity. People naturally allocate their cognitive resources, choosing between sampling from the environment and remembering information. While previous research indicates the capacity limit can be overcome with familiar stimuli, little work has explored how familiar stimuli influence allocation of VWM resources. We employed an online copying task, where participants recreated a sample/model arrangement of items to an empty workspace. We compared copy task performance with English letters and with the Brussels Artificial Character Set (BACS-2, unfamiliar condition), a set of unfamiliar characters designed to match the shape and complexity of English letters. Our results indicate that familiarity enhances VWM performance – participants inspected the model grid for less time, looked at the model grid fewer times, completed the trials faster and placed more items down in-a-row after sampling. This pattern of results suggest familiarity enables faster processing of the stimuli and a greater capacity for consolidating information. This suggests allocation of cognitive resources involves an interaction between long-term memory and VWM. One possibility is that it requires less cognitive effort to store familiar items compared to unfamiliar characters.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Perception

ID: 54 | **Method:** Quantitative

Cognitive Load and Age Estimation: Effects on Error and Tendency to Over- or Under-Estimate

According to Cognitive Load Theory (CLT), when working memory capacity is exceeded, performance on concurrent tasks deteriorates, yet its effect on facial age estimation has not been explored. In theory, greater cognitive load should cause greater error size in age estimation (accuracy) and influence the tendency to over- or underestimate (bias) due to information overload. To establish if this relationship exists, 142 participants completed an age estimation task involving estimating the age of 48 target faces. This task was paired with a simultaneous digit recall task, where participants had to remember either no digits, four digits, or seven digits, corresponding with the cognitive load conditions: no cognitive load, moderate cognitive load and high cognitive load, respectively. Results showed that cognitive load significantly impaired age estimation accuracy under both cognitive load conditions compared to the control. Interestingly, no differences emerged between moderate and high load conditions, challenging the current working memory capacity theories. Participants also consistently overestimated the age of the faces. This study provides preliminary evidence that cognitive load can disrupt perceptual age judgment. The small effect size and exploratory design indicate that further study is needed to strengthen and extend this work.

Areas: Perception; Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology

An Experimental Study of the Psychological and Behavioural Effects of CCTV in Public Spaces

In the past few decades, most economically advanced nations have witnessed a rapid rise in the use of closed-circuit television (CCTV) in public places (Lippert & Wood, 2012). Despite this, relatively few studies have examined the psychological or behavioural impact of this intrusion of surveillance into public and semi-public spaces. Accordingly, this study examined the perceived impact of variations in CCTV presence in public spaces. A total of 330 participants recruited via Prolific completed a range of individual difference measures and were allocated to a control or experimental condition. Control participants viewed a scene without CCTV and the experimental group viewed scenes in a 2 x 2 x 2 repeated measures design with varying levels of CCTV intrusiveness (large, small camera array); monitoring (salient or not salient); recording (salient or not salient). The results showed that participants exposed to a lakeside park image with visible CCTV surveillance reported lower enjoyment, reduced willingness to spend time, diminished sense of privacy, and less behavioural freedom than those exposed to a lakeside park image without visible CCTV. Additionally, larger and more intrusive CCTV, human monitoring of CCTV, and recording of CCTV each independently reduced participants' scores on all four outcome measures. Investigation of individual differences revealed a weak positive correlation between trust in the government and perceived enjoyment, willingness to spend time, and sense of privacy; however, not with behavioural freedom. No significant correlations were identified between public self-consciousness, extraversion, or political orientation and any outcome measures. This study provides valuable evidence regarding the pervasiveness of CCTV in public spaces that are often central to social and personal lives.

Areas: Social Psychology; Environmental Psychology

ID: 56 | Method: Qualitative (Content Analysis)

Senior Secondary Students' Suggestions for Improving School-Based Wellbeing Support: An Exploratory Qualitative Content Analysis of Student Voices

For senior secondary students, schooling is a central life experience that informs wellbeing outcomes. The final years of secondary schooling are often associated with academic, interpersonal, and emotional stressors. Existing research indicates that senior students are vulnerable to worsened mental health outcomes due to school-based stressors. Schools pose as convenient settings to support students through positive school climate and wellbeing interventions. However, there is rarely direct student input in developing school-based programs and limited research investigating senior students' perceptions of wellbeing supportive school climate or effective interventions. Previous literature indicates that student voice is pivotal in increasing engagement with health interventions. To address this research gap, a reflexive content analysis was conducted on secondary survey data from Year 11-12 students, analysing their free-text responses about perceived solutions to improve wellbeing, with responses pertaining to school wellbeing selected for analysis. Seven overarching categories were developed: Reduce Academic Stress and Pressure, Encourage School-Life Balance, Improve Curriculum and Delivery, Improve School Wellbeing Programs, Develop Positive School Climate, Improve Negative School Climate, and Increase Student Autonomy. Findings revealed the challenges of assessment pressures and increased workload while emphasising the importance of an autonomy-supportive school climate. Suggested solutions included employing responsive wellbeing interventions, developing flexible curricula and learning delivery options, and promoting a supportive school climate. These findings highlight how students' needs for increased agency and meaningful participation shape a positive educational experience. Further research incorporating student voice is needed to improve educational policies and develop codesigned universal interventions to support senior secondary student wellbeing.

Areas: Social Psychology; Educational Psychology; Positive Psychology

Social Media Influence Campaigns: Effects on Political Beliefs and Feelings

Internationally, malign actors are deploying coordinated influence campaigns on social media platforms, displaying intent to amplify ideological and affective polarisation – divisions in political beliefs and negative feelings toward opposing partisans. However, existing literature provides no causal evidence as to whether exposure to social media influence campaigns shift political beliefs and feelings. Moreover, no studies have investigated whether influence campaign exposure affects selective exposure, a form of confirmation bias which contributes to polarisation. Whether the presence of influence campaigns indirectly contributes to polarisation is also unclear. To address these gaps, pre-existing data from a semi-naturalistic experiment using a mock Twitter platform was analysed. US participants (N = 311) interacted on the platform over three days after being prompted to discuss four political topics and randomly allocated into one of three conditions: a platform with left-leaning Confederate accounts posting on the topics, one with right-leaning Confederate accounts, and a control. Pre-and-post experiment ratings measured shifts and polarisation in participants' beliefs towards the political topics and feelings toward political parties. Confederate exposure and selective exposure were measured using self-reported political identity and in-experiment viewing and clicking behaviours. Results showed the presence of Confederate accounts did not cause significant shifts or polarisation of political beliefs and feelings, nor changes in selective exposure. However, Democrat participants in the left-leaning condition were significantly more likely to engage in selective exposure than Republicans and Independents. These findings suggest that influence campaigns may not directly shift political attitudes but may indirectly contribute to polarisation by shaping information-seeking behaviours.

Areas: Social Psychology; Political Psychology; Cyberpsychology

Is It Too Late Now to Say Sorry? Victim Perceptions of Conciliatory Behaviour With and Without Apology

Apologies are widely regarded as one of the most important conciliatory behaviours following interpersonal transgressions. However, relatively little research has examined whether apologies enhance or undermine victims' perceptions of offenders' motives for reconciliation. Building on the motive-attribution framework (Gollwitzer & Okimoto, 2021), the present study investigated how varying levels of apology intensity (no apology, moderate apology, excessive apology) shape victims' perceptions of offender motives. The present study examined whether victims' perceptions of offenders' goals (e.g., value affirmation, moral integrity, guilt/regret) mediate the relationship between apology condition and broader motive attributions (e.g., relationship-oriented vs. self-oriented motives). Using a between-subjects, single-factor experimental design, 338 participants from the United States were randomly assigned to read a vignette describing a transgression followed by an offender response. Participants then rated the offender's perceived motives for the behaviour, including value affirmation, moral integrity, avoidance, and guilt/regret.

Areas: Social Psychology

ID: 59 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

‘Navigating university with ADHD: Exploring students’ experiences of identity, emotion and academic interactions’

University can be intellectually enriching, personally rewarding, and demanding on both time and cognition. Research suggests that students with Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) experience academic underachievement associated with symptomology. Despite increasing awareness of neurodiversity in higher education, students with ADHD remain underrepresented in academic discourse, particularly in how they navigate their identities and emotions. This qualitative study adopted a pragmatic approach to explore how students diagnosed with ADHD, and studying at a university in Australia, experience and manage their identities and emotions for university learning. Transcripts from five focus groups involving 27 participants were explored through Reflexive Thematic Analysis. Findings indicate that students’ do not always associate ADHD with their identity or consider their symptoms disabling, which can affect help-seeking behaviours, particularly when university services are promoted as disability support. Participants described extensive cognitive labour associated with learning tasks and interactions which often required emotional labour tactics to manage or suppress emotions. The cognitive labour-emotional labour cycle was also evident in help-seeking behaviours. Furthermore, participants reported conscious emotion work both in classroom interactions and when help-seeking to communicate distress and genuine need for support. Participants shared that they value support received from family, peers and teachers and described the tools and self-developed strategies they use to mitigate the impact of ADHD symptoms on learning. Finally, participants revealed their desire to be seen as individuals who learn in different ways, to feel understood by teaching staff and to enjoy a sense of belonging at university.

Areas: Educational Psychology

The Impact of Mental Illness Stigma on Mock Juror Perceptions of Victims in Criminal Trial Cases

Mental health stigma in a legal setting leads to biased decision making. Research has demonstrated that jurors' perceptions of offenders are influenced by mental illness diagnoses. However, there is very limited research on stigma towards victims with a mental illness, despite their greater vulnerability to victimisation. Further, as perceptions are shaped by multiple factors, the role of interacting factors also requires consideration. The present study investigated whether victim mental health status and victim description (positive vs. negative) influence perceptions in a legal context. Using a mixed experimental design, participants (N = 166) were randomly assigned to one of three mental health status conditions (No Mental Illness, Borderline Personality Disorder (BPD), or Alcohol Use Disorder (AUD)). Participants viewed two vignettes depicting a domestic violence case summary, with differently described victims. Participants rated perpetrator guilt, victim credibility, victim blame, and sympathy for the victim. Contrary to predictions, guilt and sympathy ratings did not significantly differ by mental health status or victim description. In line with predictions, victims with a mental illness were rated as significantly less credible than those with no mental illness, and those described negatively were also rated as significantly less credible. Notably, there was a significant interaction, such that the impact of victim description on credibility ratings was strengthened when the victim had an AUD diagnosis. Further, participants attributed significantly more blame to victims with AUD. The study extended the understanding of how mental illness stigma and victim description influence perceptions, highlighting the need for greater awareness and interventions to reduce stigma towards victims with mental illness.

Areas: Forensic Psychology; Social Psychology; Clinical Psychology; Criminology

ID: 61 | **Method:** Mixed-Methods (Content Analysis)

Political persuasion on social media: a study of online language use and belief change

The growing space for political discussion on social media gives rise to how these spaces are used to influence belief change across broad audiences. While persuasion has been largely explored through interpersonal and mainstream media spaces, it has been difficult to measure the impact of persuasive language on engagement and political persuasion on social media. This paper uses results from an isolated social media platform named Magpie Social, to explore how online ecologies influence engagement and belief change by using a content analysis of the posts to categorise them as left, right or neutral, and high, medium or low on a cognitive and affective language scale. Participants were asked to discuss topics relevant to the current political climate, as well as completing pre and post surveys measuring beliefs, allowing for the exploration of quantitative variables while still using a naturalistic social media environment. Across a week 346 participants were placed in one of three between-subject conditions: a Control, in which there was no manipulation of the environment, and a Left and Right condition in which experimenters anonymously shared posts relevant to the political alignment of the condition. These results will be used to explore if there is a significant relationship between cognitive/affective persuasive language and how right or left wing ideologies are expressed, and how this use of language influences post engagement and belief change.

Areas: Social Psychology

ID: 62 | Method: Mixed-Methods (Hybrid Thematic Analysis)

‘I’m dying: And then what?’: A Mixed-Methods Study of Public Perceptions of Death Doulas in Australia.

Australia has a growing death-positive movement promoting the need for more open, honest and personalised approaches to end-of-life care. Death doulas (DD) are non-medical professionals who support people with life-limiting illnesses and their families. They aim to improve death literacy, promote dignity and bridge gaps in the healthcare system through person-centred care. Despite their growing presence, knowledge of how the public perceives and understands the DD role remains limited in literature. This study investigated whether awareness, attitudes, perceived accessibility and potential demand influence intention to engage with DD services. Participants (N = 316) completed an online cross-sectional survey. Guided by the Information-Motivation-Behavioural Skills (IMB) model, a multiple regression was performed with qualitative data analysed using hybrid thematic analysis. Motivation (attitudes and perceived demand) was the only significant predictor ($\beta = .81$, $p < .001$). Higher levels of motivation predicted a greater likelihood of engaging with death doula services. Information captured death doulas as providers of Practical Support, Advocacy and Choice, Peace at the end of life and educators in death literacy. Motivation reflected participants’ interest in objectivity, a ‘good death’ and relief from family burden as reasons to engage with doulas, whereas cultural attitudes, intrusiveness, regulation, and situational factors created hesitation. Behavioural skills highlighted barriers including difficulty locating doulas, limited availability and affordability concerns. These findings suggest that while participants held generally positive views of death doulas, concerns around uncertainty of intrusiveness, lack of regulation and cost constrain engagement. This highlights the need for greater policy support, regulation and accessibility to strengthen Australians’ intention to engage with death doula services.

Areas: Health Psychology; Community Psychology; Social Psychology

ID: 63 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

"He went from being a kid who would skip out the door to school to being one who wouldn't get dressed to leave the house": A Qualitative Exploration of Parents' and Caregivers' Perspectives on the Initial Onset of School Refusal

School refusal (SR), referring to the difficulty of attending school due to emotional distress, is related to several adverse outcomes, including low school attachment, low academic achievement, emotional distress, social withdrawal and mental health problems. Despite the growing literature, studies that explore the perspectives of parents and caregivers remain limited, particularly within the Australian context. This qualitative study explored parents' and caregivers' experiences and perspectives around the initial onset of school refusal in adolescents aged 13-16, and what factors they perceive to have contributed to its development. The study design employed an online qualitative survey to collect original textual data in responses to open-ended survey questions. Five overarching themes were generated through Reflexive Thematic Analysis: Unsafe Learning Environment; Severe Emotional Distress; Rigid Pedagogical Climate; Social Disconnect; Blame and Minimisation. Guided by Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, the main findings highlighted the complex interplay between individual and environmental factors in shaping the initial onset of school refusal. The quality of student-teacher relationships, pedagogy and social connectedness, situated within the microsystem, either served as a risk factor or protective factor. Negative interactions between parents and the education system, situated within the mesosystem, were responsible for the minimisation of early warning signs as 'defiance'. Significant life transitions, such as moving schools, were common triggers within the Chronosystem. Moreover, Neurodevelopmental Disorders and Mental Health Disorders were identified as individual predisposing factors, meaning that some children were more vulnerable to risk factors than others. These findings highlight the acute need for early intervention and a focus on individual support and wellbeing within the school environment. Key Words: School refusal, School attendance, Parent perspectives, Adolescents, Bio-ecological theory

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Educational Psychology

Cognitive Reserve and Parkinson's Disease: Investigating Resting Tremor as a Compensatory Mechanism

Cognitive reserve (CR) is a theoretical construct proposed to explain the mismatch between pathological severity and observed functional deficits in neurodegenerative disease (Stern, 2009). In Parkinson's disease (PD), resting tremor is uniquely associated with reduced deficit, favourable disease course, and unpredictable response to dopaminergic medication, leading some to propose resting tremor as a compensatory mechanism for other parkinsonian motor symptoms (Helmich et al., 2012). However, research in this area is limited. The present study used CR to investigate the compensatory potential of resting tremor and evaluate the influence of premorbid experiences on neurological resilience. Ninety-four PD patients completed a test battery measuring CR proxies, resting tremor severity, and dopamine-modulated behavioural outcomes. A moderated mediation analysis explored the compensatory potential of resting tremor through its mediation of the CR-behavioural outcomes relationship across different disease durations. Fifty-eight PD patients underwent diffusion-weighted MRI scans; tract-based spatial statistics were used to identify differences in white matter integrity associated with resting tremor and CR, respectively. Behavioural outcomes were significantly associated with both CR and resting tremor. However, behavioural outcomes declined with increasing tremor severity. A weakly significant mediation effect was found despite no significant relationship between CR and resting tremor. All effects weakened with longer disease duration. No significant associations with white matter integrity were found. These findings did not support resting tremor as a compensatory mechanism but are consistent with CR literature and provide additional insight into the impacts of lifestyle factors on resilience in neurodegenerative disease. Keywords: cognitive reserve, Parkinson's disease, resting tremor, mediation, diffusion tensor imaging

Areas: Clinical Neuropsychology; Cognitive Psychology; Biological Psychology

Integrating Just World, Free Will, and Moral Responsibility Beliefs to Predict Authoritarianism.

Political polarisation is escalating across Western countries, fuelling violence and eroding democracy. However, how fundamental beliefs about justice, free will, and moral responsibility jointly underpin right-wing authoritarianism (RWA) and left-wing authoritarianism (LWA) remains underspecified. This study aimed to investigate whether belief in a just world for others (BJW-other) and BJW for the self (BJW-self) respectively predict RWA and LWA, and examine the roles of belief in free will (BFW) and belief in moral responsibility (BMR) in these associations. I hypothesised a moderated mediation model where BJW-other would exert a conditional indirect effect on RWA via BMR as a function of BFW, and a conditional direct effect on RWA as a function of BFW. BJW-self and LWA were respectively treated as an exploratory predictor and exploratory outcome. This cross-sectional study surveyed 196 participants online, recruited via the University of Adelaide's SONA Research Participation System and SurveyCircle. I employed structural equation modelling and found that BJW-other and BJW-self did not exert the conditional indirect and conditional direct effects on RWA in the primary and exploratory moderated mediation models. Follow-up exploratory analyses showed that both BJW-other and BJW-self exerted positive serial indirect effects on RWA sequentially via BFW and BMR. Nevertheless, LWA was not correlated with other variables except for RWA. These results have implications for providing a theoretical connection between justice motive theory, classic attribution theory and dual-process motivational model, and informing practical interventions to mitigate RWA through targeted moral education. Future research should examine additional fundamental beliefs and mechanisms underlying LWA.

Areas: Social Psychology; Individual Differences; Political Psychology

ID: 66 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

"My client is the manual": Thematic analysis of individualist and systematic tensions in Australian perinatal psychologists' attitudes, behaviours and priorities when caring for LGBTQIA+ clients.

The perinatal period, as a time of significant physical and social transition, represents a time of increased vulnerability to mental health challenges. As viewed from an intersectional lens, these challenges may be exacerbated by existing experiences of marginalisation for groups such as LGBTQIA+ individuals—a difficulty compounded by the highly gendered nature of prescribed parenting roles and the presence of these heteronormative expectations in perinatal health services. This study aimed to explore the attitudes, behaviours and perceived preparedness for work of Australian perinatal psychologists with regards to supporting LGBTQIA+ clients, in their role as mental health service providers during this vulnerable time. A digital, exploratory qualitative survey was developed and distributed to clinicians across Australia with public-facing contact email addresses. Forty-three participants responded either wholly (N=32) or partially (N=9), and reflexive thematic analysis was used within a framework of critical realism to develop five themes: "My client is the manual"—Centering client-led care approaches; "I know I won't provide perfect care" —Clinicians' self-conception as flawed care providers; "Uni didn't prepare me for this"—Experience as the primary learning resource; and "Beyond the therapy room" — The psychologist as a community member with related responsibilities. Results indicated a high value placed on client-led and person-centred care in determining individual care approaches and the importance of not making assumptions about client needs, with varying degrees of importance placed on the contextualisation of this knowledge within social systems. A strong desire for increased training, and the improvement of existing training programs, was indicated.

Areas: Cultural Psychology; Social Psychology; Public Health; LGBTQ+ Studies

Victim Satisfaction in the Wake of Offender Moral Change: Exploring the Underlying Psychological Mechanisms

Retaliations to injustice such as punishment and revenge has long been viewed as a pathway to justice satisfaction, however, emerging research suggests that such retaliations are not as satisfying as once assumed. Instead, victim's report more justice satisfaction from an offenders' expression of moral change. The present study aimed to understand what about moral change expressions are satisfying to victims. We hypothesised that moral change would lower perceived offender entitlement, and increase offender-perceived victim power, with both mediating greater justice satisfaction. We further hypothesised punishment would moderate moral changes effects on the mediators making them stronger with punishment present. The study used a 2 (punishment: yes, vs no) x 2 (moral change: yes, vs no) between subject's experimental design administered online through vignettes. Through convenience sampling 388 participants participated in the study and were a representative sample of the United States. Results showed that moral change significantly reduced offender entitlement and increased offender-perceived victim power, both of which mediated moral changes positive effect on justice satisfaction. However, contrary to predictions punishment did not moderate moral changes effect on offender entitlement and offender-perceived victim power. The findings demonstrate that interpersonal communication and perspective taking rather than intrapersonal restoration is key in understanding what about moral change expressions are satisfying for victims. The current study advances justice theory by clarifying how moral change fosters satisfaction beyond punishment and has implications for informing restoration practices and conflict resolution.

Areas: Criminology; Social Psychology; Forensic Psychology

ID: 68 | **Method:** Qualitative (Content Analysis)

High School Psychology in Regional, Rural, and Remote Australia: Teacher perceptions of challenges and opportunities

Psychologist shortages in regional, rural, and remote (RRR) Australia are a critical issue, prompting interest in rural psychology education and the potential of developing a “rural pipeline” to psychology practice, beginning in secondary school. In response, this study aimed to explore how high school psychology teachers in RRR Australia experience the delivery of psychology education and what they perceive as key factors influencing students’ engagement with and access to psychology education and career pathways. Fifteen teachers from South Australia, Western Australia, and the Northern Territory participated in an online qualitative survey, comprising free-text questions alongside demographic and quantitative items to contextualise responses. Participants were secondary teachers delivering Year 11 and/or 12 psychology to students in these areas via face-to-face methods, distance education, or a combination of the two. Responses were analysed using reflexive qualitative content analysis, which identified four overarching categories: Teacher Preparation and Support, Structural and Delivery Barriers, Student Interest and Engagement, and Career Pathway Access and Barriers. Findings point to systemic issues in psychology teacher preparation and support, curriculum delivery, and tertiary access to psychology studies that collectively hinder the development of a rural psychology pipeline. These preliminary insights highlight the need for further research into the structural and contextual factors shaping psychology education in RRR areas. Supporting teachers and improving student access to information and opportunities may be important steps toward strengthening the rural psychology pipeline and addressing workforce shortages in RRR areas.

Areas: Community Psychology; Educational Psychology; Rural Psychology

Conversational AI and Memory: Investigating False Memory Formation in Witness Interviews

In recent years, generative artificial intelligence (AI) systems, particularly large language models (LLMs), have rapidly advanced to produce highly fluent and contextually relevant natural language. As human–AI interactions become increasingly integrated into daily life, questions regarding the impact of conversational AI on human cognition arise. A recent study by Chan et al. (2023) found that interaction with a generative AI chatbot significantly increased false memory formation in an eyewitness interview task. This effect is especially concerning given the well-known issue of AI hallucinations, where LLMs generate false or fabricated content that is presented with high fluency and confidence. The current study aims to replicate and extend this research by introducing a neutral generative chatbot condition to isolate the role of response style. Participants ($N \approx 140$) watched CCTV footage of a robbery before completing a structured interview conducted by one of four chatbot conditions: confirmatory AI, neutral AI, pre-scripted (non-generative) chatbot, or control (no AI). False memories were measured through a post-interview questionnaire, with source monitoring errors measured by participants' attributions of memory origins. Machines as Social Entities (MASE) scale (Epley et al., 2007) was used to explore the moderating role of AI perception. Planned analyses include generalised linear mixed-effects models (GLMMs) with fixed effects for condition and continuous predictors, and random intercepts for participants and items. Hypotheses predict higher false memory rates in the confirmatory condition relative to other groups, greater source monitoring errors in generative versus non-generative conditions, and a positive association between MASE scores and false memories.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology

Additional feature load does not impact allocation of visual working memory resources

Visual working memory (VWM) is the system that allows us to temporarily store visual information to guide behaviour. A central debate is whether VWM capacity is limited by the complexity of what is held in memory. It has been shown that adding features like shape, colour, and orientation to the to-be-remembered items reduces performance; but this reduction is small when compared to increasing the number of to-be-remembered items. However, in everyday life, we often do not choose to use VWM to its maximum capacity. This study used a novel pattern copy task, in which participants copy an array of items (the model) into an empty grid. Participants choose how much information to memorise and how often to refer back to the model grid. 72 participants completed trials with either simple stimuli (black artificial characters) or complex stimuli with added feature load (coloured characters). One group of subjects completed the task with interleaved trials, whereas two other groups of subjects completed the trials in blocked (simple then complex; complex then simple). Across outcome measures, there was no main effect of feature-load – the complexity of the stimulus did not change copy task performance. These findings suggest that VWM resource allocation may operate in an object-based manner. There was an interaction between trial order and task performance. In the blocked conditions, participants were fastest in their second condition. This suggests performance improvements come from practice rather than any strategic allocation of resources. Keywords: visual working memory, conjunction, pattern copy task, ecological validity

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Experimental Psychology; Visual Cognition

Psychosocial Safety Climate, Work Self- Efficacy, Anxiety and Intention to leave in Australian Employees with Multiple Sclerosis.

Diversity in modern workplaces includes the need to accommodate the growing challenges for employees and work climates to include those with chronic illnesses. Although previous organisational psychology research considered experiences related to psychosocial factors that provide inclusive workplace environments for general employees, a gap exists for outcomes in employees with Multiple Sclerosis (MS). Current studies used cross-sectional design, with theoretical underpinnings from both Psychosocial Safety Climate (PSC) and Social Cognitive Theory to consider predictive, motivational pathways outcomes in context of workplace health. Observational data taken from The Australian MS Longitudinal 2021 study was investigated to explore the mediating role of work self-efficacy and anxiety between PSC and intention to leave for employees with MS. Investigation of 457 recruited employees with MS found 84.4% were female, mean age was 50.7 years, and 69.5% were diagnosed with MS prior to current work. Structural equation modelling (SEM) path analyses used robust maximum likelihood estimation, which revealed PSC is positively related to work self-efficacy, however negatively for intention to leave and anxiety. Model specification adjusted to remove anxiety, improved overall fit substantially, with saturated model ($\chi^2(0) = 0.00$, RMSEA = .000 and CFI = 1.000), while retaining significant direct and indirect effects of PSC on intention to leave, via work self-efficacy (β indirect = -.031). Findings suggest PSC was a significant determinant on both work self-efficacy and intention to leave, with work self-efficacy a primary motivator of workplace safety, found to mediate these relationships. These results highlight the importance of positive organisational health to increase the self-belief, well-being, retention and psychological support of members who live while managing Multiple Sclerosis symptoms in their workplace. Key words: psychosocial safety climate (PSC), work self-efficacy, intention to leave, multiple sclerosis, workplace safety

Areas: Organisational Psychology; Health Psychology; Public Health; Social Psychology

ID: 72 | Method: Qualitative (Thematic Analysis)

Exploring a Complete School-based Executive Functioning Intervention Program for High School Students: Educational Stakeholders' Perspectives Towards Student Selection, Curriculum, and Program Execution

Currently, South Australian high schools do not have an Executive Functioning (EF) program that is both evidence-based and feasible for school wide implementation. While some programs exist, they face significant logistical challenges that limit their effectiveness, including poor far skill transferability, limited involvement of key educational stakeholders (teachers, wellbeing staff, and parents), and inadequate integration of psychological theory such as the Triad Model of EF. There is also a lack of research into curriculum design that addresses these gaps while incorporating stakeholder perspectives, an essential factor for ensuring sustainable, long-term impact on skill development. This study explored these considerations through two focus groups involving eight participants, through Reflexive Thematic Analysis within a critical realist framework. Four key themes were developed: 'EF program curriculum and pedagogy', 'ready to implement', 'student agency-led reflection', and 'validating the program and measuring skill progression'. Findings indicated that to best support far-skill transfer, an EF program should be centered on students' metacognitive reflection and embedded in real life contexts. Effective implementation also requires: sector wide adoption with long term commitment, active facilitation by both teachers and parents, the provision of comprehensive curricula and teaching resources, and validation through empirical and longitudinal research. The study recommends integrating EF skill development into school curricula, enhancing teacher education programs to include EF training, and provide ongoing Professional Development (PD) for current teachers, well-being staff, and SSO's. These recommendations may provide the foundation for an EF support program in South Australian high Schools.

Areas: Educational Psychology

Boundary Extension Attenuates at the Iconic Memory for Highly Arousing Imagery.

Termed the boundary extension effect, people often expand the boundaries of a scene in memory to be larger than in reality. Since Safer et al., 1998 researchers have been investigating how emotional imagery impacts this effect. It was originally found that the effect inverts, creating boundary restriction, where scenes are remembered as being narrower. Over the past 30 years, this effect has been sparsely replicated, as most studies find boundary extension. A remarkable aspect of boundary extension is it can be found immediately after encoding, in iconic memory. However, all previous studies involving emotion test boundary extension in long-term memory, thus leaving an unexplored area of memory: iconic memory. In a between-subjects design, we showed 140 participants neutral or negatively valenced-high arousal scenes for 250 ms, interrupted the view with a 42 ms visual mask, then re-presented the same image. We then asked participants how much the image had changed. After just 42ms, participants in the neutral condition made boundary extension errors, and participants in the arousal condition made significantly less boundary extension errors. Participants in the arousal condition did not make more restriction errors, but were actually more accurate in their memory of scenes. Potentially, the early perceptual stages of visual memory are home to unique attentional and perceptual effects, but are fleeting and dissipate with time.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology

Emotional Regulation in Children and Adolescents with Autism: A Meta-Analysis of Interventions across Mainstream and Special Education Settings

Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) is a neurodevelopmental condition frequently associated with difficulties in Emotional Regulation (ER), which can negatively impact social functioning and academic engagement. Schools represent a critical environment for supporting ER development, yet little is known about the relative effectiveness of interventions across mainstream and special education settings. This systematic review and meta-analysis, conducted in accordance with PRISMA guidelines and pre-registered on the Open Science Framework, aimed to evaluate the effectiveness of school-based interventions targeting ER in children and adolescents with ASD. A comprehensive search of six databases identified 3826 papers, with 23 studies meeting eligibility criteria following screening. Studies were included if they examined ER as a primary outcome, focused on participants aged 5-18 years with a formal diagnosis of ASD, and delivered interventions in either mainstream or special education settings. Data extraction captured demographic, methodological, and outcome variables, with study quality being appraised using the QualSyst tool. Findings indicate that while school-based ER interventions can improve emotional awareness, coping strategies, and behavioural outcomes, the effectiveness of approaches varies depending on contextual factors such as education setting, teacher training, and staff-to-student ratios. However, evidence directly comparing mainstream and special education environments remains scarce, highlighting a significant gap in the literature. These findings emphasise the need for further comparative research to guide the development of inclusive, evidence-based practices that enhance ER skills among autistic students across diverse school contexts.

Areas: Developmental Psychology; Educational Psychology

ID: 75 | **Method:** Quantitative

The Role of Information Security Awareness, Decision-Making and Phishing Knowledge in Phishing Email Detection: A Moderated Mediation Analysis

The current study explored the roles of email information security awareness, decision-making styles, phishing knowledge and time spent viewing emails in phishing detection, and whether the time spent viewing emails mediated this relationship. Participants (N = 127) completed an online email sorting task, a measure of information security awareness, a scale to assess decision-making style preference (intuitive/rational) and a test of phishing email knowledge. Mediation analyses concluded that the effect of decision style preference on phishing detection was fully mediated by time spent viewing emails. Intuitive decision-making was associated with decreased time spent viewing emails and rational decision-making was linked with greater time spent viewing emails. Longer time spent viewing emails was associated with enhanced detection. Moderated mediation analyses revealed that information security awareness was not directly correlated with decision-making styles or time spent viewing emails. The effect of time spent viewing emails on phishing detection was moderated by phishing knowledge. Longer email viewing times were associated with augmented phishing detection when phishing knowledge was median or high, but not low. These findings showcased that extended time spent viewing emails constitutes a critical factor in mitigating phishing susceptibility, with individuals possessing higher levels of phishing knowledge benefiting the most. From an applied perspective, the results indicate that anti-phishing training programs may be most effective by emphasising the importance of allocating sufficient time to evaluate email content, whilst also establishing a baseline level of phishing knowledge to enhance training outcomes.

Areas: Applied Psychology

Impacts of parent's adverse childhood experiences on their parenting style and children's internalising and externalising behaviours: Evidence from the Longitudinal Study of Australian Children

Adverse childhood experiences (ACEs) are known to impact long-term health and development, yet their intergenerational effects on parenting and adolescent wellbeing remain underexplored in Australia. This study examined the relationship between parental ACE exposure, parenting behaviours (hostility and self-efficacy), and adolescent internalising and externalising outcomes at ages 16-17. It was hypothesised that parents with high ACE exposure would report higher hostility and lower self-efficacy, and that their children would be more likely to score in the borderline/abnormal range on the Strengths and Difficulties Questionnaire (SDQ). Using data from the Longitudinal Study of Australian Children (LSAC), the sample included 2,827 parent-child dyads. Logistic regression analyses were conducted, adjusting for parental education and socio-economic disadvantage. Results showed that high parental ACE exposure was significantly associated with increased odds of low parenting self-efficacy and high parenting hostility. Adolescents of parents with high ACE exposure had greater odds of scoring in the borderline/abnormal range on the SDQ total difficulties and hyperactivity subscales. Post-hoc analyses revealed that parental experiences of abuse were most strongly associated with adolescent emotional and behavioural difficulties. These findings contribute to the literature on intergenerational adversity and highlight the importance of identifying families at risk. Implications include the need for early screening and trauma-informed support for parents, particularly in communities disproportionately affected by adversity.

Areas: Public Health; Developmental Psychology; Clinical Psychology

ID: 77 | **Method:** Quantitative

Masculinity and Mental Health Help-Seeking: Applying Andersen's Behavioural Model to Psychology Service Use Among Australian Men

Men remain underrepresented among users of psychological services despite experiencing significant burdens of depression, anxiety and suicidal ideation. Guided by Andersen's Behavioural Model (ABM) of Health Service Utilisation, this study examined predisposing, enabling and need factors associated with psychology service use among Australian men with elevated symptoms of depression, anxiety, or suicidal ideation, with a specific focus on the role of traditional masculinity. Data was drawn from the Ten to Men: Longitudinal Study of Australian Male Health (N = 2045). Hierarchical logistic regressions were conducted with variables entered sequentially in blocks corresponding to ABM domains, and self-reported psychology service use as the primary outcome. Results indicated that predisposing, enabling and need factors each explained additional variance in service use, with progressive improvements in model fit. In the final model, traditional masculinity, tertiary education, depression symptoms and anxiety symptoms significantly influenced psychology service use. These findings highlight the importance of considering social determinants, traditional masculinity and clinical need when addressing barriers to men's mental health help-seeking.

Areas: Health Psychology; Public Health; Clinical Psychology

What Gives? Analysing the Effectiveness of Psychological Interventions for Informal Caregivers of Adults with Dementia. A Meta-Analysis of Randomised Controlled Trials.

Dementia is progressive neurological disorder that is caused by injuries, viruses, and lifestyle factors. It is the main cause of death among women and the second among men in Australia. It not only affects the person directly, but also the informal caregivers who care for them. Numerous studies have documented the negative effects caregiving has on informal caregivers such as elevated stress, depression and anxiety. However, literature has also shown that caregiving can result in improved positive outcomes based on two wellbeing dimensions: eudaimonic and hedonic. Psychological interventions such as psychoeducation, cognitive behaviour therapy, and mindfulness have been analysed and documented to improve resilience, self-efficacy, and personal growth among caregivers. Previous meta-analyses have taken a deficit approach with a primary focus on the negative effects of caregiving. This review of 27 independent studies featuring 4,074 informal caregivers will focus on the efficacy of interventions to improve caregiver wellbeing based on the two aforementioned dimensions. Moderator analyses were conducted to measure how differences in interventions such as duration, format, and control group, can affect the efficacy of the interventions. Group and individual-based formats were significant in comparison to interventions employing a mixture of both whilst studies using non-directive and waitlist control groups also yielded significant results. The individual differences in interventions highlight the need for a more personalised approach in designing future psychological interventions to target specific caregiver needs.

Areas: Cognitive Psychology; Positive Psychology; Health Psychology